

HEB collaborates with TCR signaling to upregulate *Id3* and enable $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell maturation in the fetal thymus

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eLife Assessment

The study provides **important** mechanistic insight into the transcriptional control of $\gamma\delta$ T17 development, elegantly demonstrating how HEB and *Id3* act sequentially and cooperatively to regulate $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell specification and maturation. The study provides **compelling** evidence that advances the understanding of E-Id protein dynamics in thymic T cell specification. The work is comprehensive, technically rigorous, and conceptually clear, and will be of interest to immunologists, developmental biologists, and those studying the molecular underpinnings of physiological outcomes.

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Abstract

T cells expressing the $\gamma\delta$ T cell receptor (TCR) develop in a stepwise process initiating at the $\alpha\beta/\gamma\delta$ T cell lineage choice followed by maturation and acquisition of effector functions, including the ability to produce interleukin-17 (IL-17) as $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells. Previous studies linked TCR signal strength and T cell fate choices to the transcriptional regulator HEB (encoded by *Tcf12*) and its antagonist, *Id3*, but how these factors regulate different stages of $\gamma\delta$ T cell development has not been determined. We found that immature fetal $\gamma\delta$ TCR⁺ cells from conditional *Tcf12* knockout (HEB cKO) mice were defective in activating the $\gamma\delta$ T17 program at an early stage, whereas *Id3* deficient (*Id3*-KO) mice displayed a partial block in $\gamma\delta$ T17 maturation and an inability to produce IL-17. We also found that HEB cKO mice failed to upregulate *Id3* during $\gamma\delta$ T17 development, whereas HEB overexpression elevated the levels of *Id3* in collaboration with TCR signaling. Moreover, *Egr2* and HEB were bound to several of the same regulatory sites on the *Id3* gene locus in the context of early T cell development. Therefore, our findings reveal an interlinked sequence of events during which HEB and TCR signaling synergize to upregulate *Id3*, which enables maturation and acquisition of the $\gamma\delta$ T17 effector program.

One Sentence Summary

The transcription factor HEB synergizes with TCR signaling to upregulate *Id3*, which is required for the maturation of fetal IL-17-producing $\gamma\delta$ T cells.

Introduction

IL-17-producing $\gamma\delta$ T ($\gamma\delta$ T17) cells are critical effectors in immune responses to bacterial and fungal pathogens and contribute to tissue repair and barrier integrity, particularly at mucosal surfaces (1). Beyond host defense, $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells regulate adipose tissue homeostasis and metabolic function (2). However, dysregulation of $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell function has been linked to autoimmunity and neuroinflammatory disorders, underscoring the importance of precisely controlled $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell development and function (3, 4).

While significant progress has been made in defining the stages of $\gamma\delta$ T cell development, the transcriptional networks that govern lineage commitment and effector fate specification remain incompletely understood. In mice, $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells arise exclusively during fetal and early neonatal thymic development. The earliest wave of $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells in the fetal thymus, which emerges around embryonic day 17 (E17), originates from T cell precursors expressing the V γ 6 V δ 1 T cell receptor (TCR) (5, 6). A second wave of V γ 4⁺V δ 5⁺ cells, which begins at E18, also gives rise to $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells (7, 8). By contrast, fetal-restricted V γ 5⁺V δ 1⁺ $\gamma\delta$ T cells are associated with the IFN- γ -producing $\gamma\delta$ T1 fate (9, 10). Most V γ 1⁺ cells, which appear just before birth and continue to develop in the adult thymus, also differentiate into $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells (11). Although V γ 4⁺ cells continue to be generated in the adult thymus, their capacity to give rise to innate $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells is significantly diminished (7, 12, 13). Instead, adult V γ 4⁺ cells remain poised for peripheral polarization into either $\gamma\delta$ T17 or $\gamma\delta$ T1 fates (14). Other subsets, such as IL-4 producing V γ 1⁺V δ 6.3⁺ cells, emerge primarily in neonatal and young mice (15).

$\gamma\delta$ and $\alpha\beta$ T cells develop primarily from shared intrathymic T cell progenitors that lack expression of CD4 and CD8 (double-negative, DN) (16, 17). These precursors can be further subdivided by CD44 and CD25 expression, with the earliest thymic immigrants classified as CD44⁺CD25⁻, termed early thymic progenitors (ETPs). In the fetal thymus, DN2 (CD44⁺CD25⁺) cells can generate either $\gamma\delta$ T17 or $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells, while DN3 (CD44⁻CD25⁺) cells preferentially give rise to $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells or proceed to $\alpha\beta$ development following pre-TCR signaling in a process known as β -selection (18). Successful progress through β -selection is followed by upregulation of CD8 and CD4, generating CD4⁺CD8⁺ double positive (DP) cells. Commitment to the $\gamma\delta$ lineage is initiated by $\gamma\delta$ TCR signaling, which induces lineage-specifying transcription factors such as *Sox13* (19, 20), followed by effector programming factors such as *Maf*, which are gradually upregulated as differentiation proceeds (19, 21). These factors promote expression of lineage-defining cytokines such as IL-17 and their regulators, including ROR γ t (22).

TCR signal strength plays a central role in determining both the $\gamma\delta$ T cell lineage choice and $\gamma\delta$ T cell effector program (23, 24). Weak pre-TCR signals promote $\alpha\beta$ lineage progression, whereas intermediate $\gamma\delta$ TCR signaling favors $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell development, and stronger signals direct $\gamma\delta$ T1 differentiation (25, 26). Signal strength is modulated by TCR affinity, proximal CD3 signaling, and cytokine crosstalk (27–30). Together, these factors converge on downstream signal transduction pathways, including the ERK–Egr–*Id3* axis, which has been identified as a key mediator of TCR signal strength using manipulation of TCR ligands or TCR signaling pathways (10, 31–34).

Id3 encodes a dominant-negative HLH protein that inhibits the expression of E protein-dependent genes. *Id3* acts at the post-translational level by binding and sequestering E proteins, including HEB (encoded by *Tcf12*) and E2A (encoded by *Tcf3*), thereby preventing their DNA binding activity. HEB and E2A orchestrate multiple stages of $\alpha\beta$ T cell development (35–38). *Id3* expression is proportional to TCR signal strength, suggesting that it may influence T cell fate by titrating E protein activity (29, 39). Moreover, *Id3* is directly regulated by graded expression of Egr factors, linking TCR signal strength to E protein target genes (39). We previously showed that HEB-deficient mice exhibit severe defects in $\gamma\delta$ T17 development, including impaired production of fetal $V\gamma 4^+$ $\gamma\delta$ T cells and dysregulated expression of key $\gamma\delta$ T17 regulators in the $V\gamma 6^+$ subset (8). HEB directly activates early $\gamma\delta$ T17 genes, such as *Sox4* and *Sox13*, which are repressed when *Id3* is overexpressed. However, the complete physiological role of HEB in $\gamma\delta$ T cell development remains unresolved.

Here, we investigated the roles of HEB and *Id3* *in vivo* by analyzing fetal $\gamma\delta$ T cell development in *HEB^{fl/fl};Vav-iCre* (HEB conditional knockout, HEB cKO) and *Id3*-deficient (*Id3*-KO) mice using flow cytometry and single-cell RNA sequencing (scRNA-seq) of E18 thymocytes. Our results reveal a tiered disruption of $\gamma\delta$ T cell development in HEB cKO mice, including dysregulated TRVG and TRDV expression, lineage diversion to the $\alpha\beta$ program, and failure to activate key specification factors, including *Id3*. In contrast, $\gamma\delta$ T17 precursors in *Id3*-KO mice initiated the $\gamma\delta$ T17 specification program but failed to mature or produce IL-17. These findings suggest that HEB and *Id3* function in an interlinked negative feedback loop that reinforces $\gamma\delta$ lineage commitment and mediates the transition from specification to maturation during $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell development.

Results

Strategy for analyzing $\gamma\delta$ T cell developmental progression in the fetal thymus

To analyze $\gamma\delta$ T cell development by flow cytometry, we used a panel of antibodies that distinguished developmental stages and lineage fate choices in the mouse fetal thymus. $\gamma\delta$ T cells develop from DN2/3 cells in the thymus from precursors with both $\alpha\beta$ and $\gamma\delta$ T cell potential, with upregulation of CD8 (immature single positive, ISP) and CD4 marking commitment to the $\alpha\beta$ -T cell lineage (Fig. 1A). Strong $\gamma\delta$ TCR signaling results in upregulation of CD73 (*Nt5e*), followed by downregulation of CD24 (*Cd24a*) to yield mature $CD27^+CD24^-CD73^+CD44^-$ $\gamma\delta$ T1 (IFN γ producing) cells. Signaling through $V\gamma 6^+$ or $V\gamma 4^+$ TCRs results in downregulation of CD24 as $\gamma\delta$ T cell precursors differentiate into mature $CD27^-CD24^-CD73^-$ $\gamma\delta$ T17 (IL-17-producing) cells. CD27 is expressed on all immature $\gamma\delta$ T cells and stays on in mature $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells but is downregulated during $\gamma\delta$ T17 maturation. Thus, detection of $\gamma\delta$ TCR, CD4, CD8, CD24, CD73, CD27, and *Vy* chains, and the genes that encode them, provides a solid framework for analyzing the impact of gene perturbations on fetal $\gamma\delta$ T cell development and maturation.

It is important to clarify the *Vy* and *V8* chain nomenclature used in this study (Fig. 1B). Cell surface proteins detected in flow cytometry assays were classified using the Tonegawa nomenclature (40). When referring to genes or gene transcripts, the International Immunogenetics Information System (IMGT) nomenclature (41) was used, except in scRNA-seq figures where R-Seurat program output gene names from the Mouse Genome Informatics (MGI) site were preserved (42). The numbering is the same in all three systems except for *V81*, which is equivalent to *TRDV4* (IMTG) and *Trdv4* (MGI).

HEB deficiency impairs $V\gamma 4$ cell development and inhibits functional maturation of $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells in the E18 fetal thymus. To investigate how HEB loss affects fetal $\gamma\delta$ T cell development, we crossed *HEB^{fl/fl}* mice with *HEB^{fl/fl};Vav-iCre* mice to generate littermates without Cre (wildtype, WT) or with Cre (HEB cKO). HEB cKO mice lack HEB in all hematopoietic cells, as previously described (8),

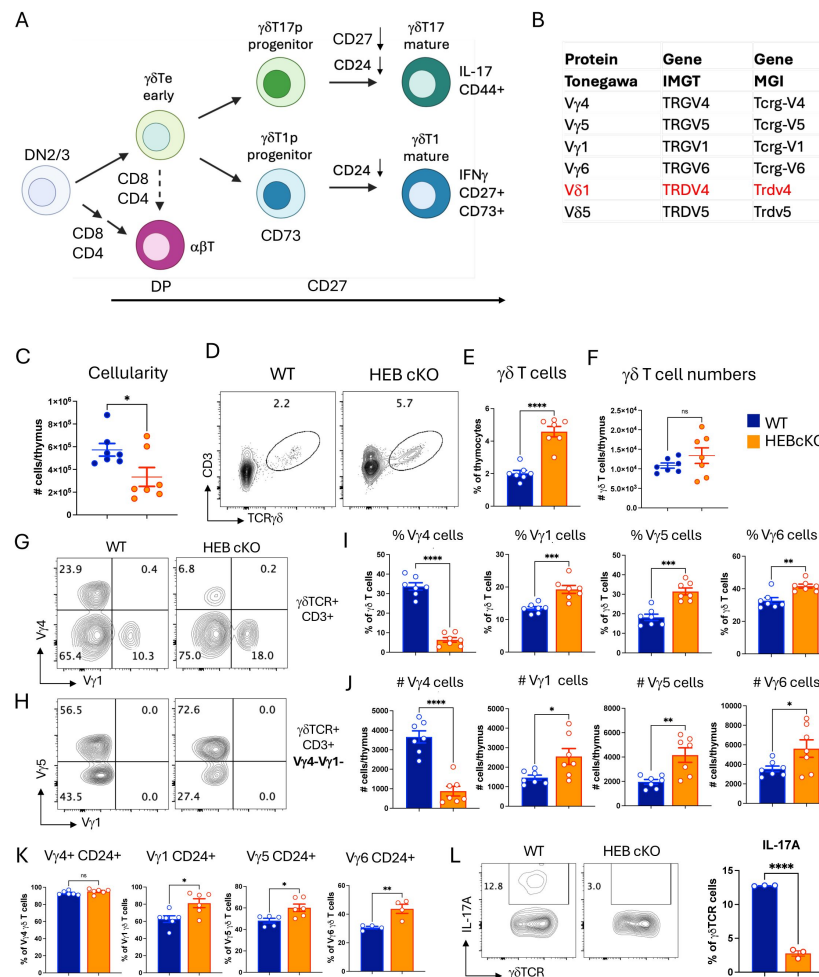


Figure 1.

Partial block in early $\gamma\delta$ T cell development and decrease in Vy4 cells in HEB-deficient mice.

A. Stages of fetal mouse $\gamma\delta$ T cell development. Thymocytes at the DN2 ($CD4^- CD8^- CD44^+ CD25^+$) and DN3 ($CD4^- CD8^- CD44^- CD25^+$) stages of T cell development rearrange and express TCR γ , TCR8, and TCR β genes. DN3 cells with productive TCR β chains expressing a pre-TCR are directed into the $\alpha\beta$ -T cell lineage, characterized by upregulation of CD4 and CD8. Cells that receive a $\gamma\delta$ TCR signal are directed into the $\gamma\delta$ T cell lineage ($\gamma\delta$ Te, early $\gamma\delta$ T cells). Surface expression of $\gamma\delta$ TCR precedes $\gamma\delta$ TCR signaling; thus, not all $\gamma\delta$ TCR $^+$ cells have committed to the $\gamma\delta$ T cell lineage, and failure to be triggered by a $\gamma\delta$ TCR ligand can divert them into the $\alpha\beta$ T cell lineage (dotted line). $\gamma\delta$ TCR $^+$ cells receiving a strong signal become CD73 $^+$ $\gamma\delta$ T1 cell progenitors ($\gamma\delta$ T1p) that mature into IFN γ producing $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells, whereas cells that receive an intermediate signal become $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell progenitors ($\gamma\delta$ T17p) that mature into IL-17 producing $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells. Downregulation of CD24 and CD27, and upregulation of CD44, marks maturation of $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells, whereas $\gamma\delta$ T1 cell maturation is characterized by downregulation of CD24 and maintenance of CD73 and CD27 expression. B. $\gamma\delta$ T cell nomenclature. Vy and V8 chain genes and proteins can be identified by several different naming systems. Here we use the Tonegawa nomenclature to refer to the proteins, and the International Immunogenetics Information System (IMGT) for the genes and transcripts. R-Seurat generated plots use the Mouse Genome Informatics (MGI) nomenclature. The numbering for genes and proteins in these three systems are identical except for the TRDV4 gene, which encodes the Vy1 protein (highlighted in red). C. Absolute numbers of cells per thymus in WT (blue) and HEB cKO (orange) E18 fetal mice. D, E. Percentages of $\gamma\delta$ T cells in WT and HEB cKO fetal thymus. F. Absolute number of $\gamma\delta$ T cells per thymus in WT and HEB cKO fetal thymus. G. Flow cytometry plots of Vy4 $^+$ and Vy1 $^+$ cells within the $\gamma\delta$ T cell population in WT and HEB cKO fetal thymus. H. Flow cytometry plot of Vy5 and Vy6 (Vy1 $^+$ Vy5 $^-$) expression on cells within the Vy1 $^+$ Vy4 $^-$ population. I. Percentages of Vy1 $^+$, Vy4 $^+$, Vy5 $^+$, and Vy6 $^+$ cells out of all $\gamma\delta$ T cells in the WT and HEB cKO fetal thymus. J. Absolute numbers of Vy1 $^+$, Vy4 $^+$, Vy5 $^+$, and Vy6 $^+$ cells per WT and HEB cKO fetal thymus. K. Percentages of immature (CD24 $^+$) and mature (CD24 $^-$) $\gamma\delta$ T cells out of all $\gamma\delta$ T cells in each Vy subset in WT and HEB cKO fetal thymus. L. Expression of IL-17A protein in $\gamma\delta$ T cells from E18 thymus stimulated with PMA/ionomycin as assessed by intracellular staining. Blue = WT, orange = HEB cKO. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$, **** $p < 0.0001$.

43 [43](#)). At embryonic day 18 (E18), HEB cKO thymocytes showed reduced cellularity (**Fig. 1C** [43](#)) and a developmental block at the ISP-to-DP transition (**Suppl. Fig. 1** [43](#)), as previously reported in adult HEB-deficient mice ([44](#) [45](#)). Although $\gamma\delta$ T cells were proportionally increased in HEB cKO mice (**Fig. 1D, E** [43](#)), their absolute numbers were comparable to WT mice (**Fig. 1F** [43](#)), indicating that the reduced cellularity was primarily due to loss of DP thymocytes.

We next analyzed V γ chain subsets. HEB cKO mice exhibited a marked reduction in the frequency (**Fig. 1G, I** [43](#)) and absolute numbers of V γ 4⁺ cells (**Fig. 1J** [43](#)), and a corresponding increase in the other V γ subsets (**Fig. 1G, H, I, J** [43](#)). Immature (CD24⁺) cells were more prevalent across all V γ subsets in HEB cKO mice, except for V γ 4⁺ cells, which had not yet matured in either WT or HEB cKO mice (**Fig. 1K** [43](#)). Furthermore, fetal HEB cKO $\gamma\delta$ T cells showed a major impairment in IL-17 production (**Fig. 1L** [43](#)), consistent with our prior fetal thymic organ culture (FTOC) results ([8](#) [43](#)). These findings indicate that even in the intact E18 thymic environment, HEB is essential for $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell development.

Single-cell transcriptomic analysis reveals a role for HEB in establishing $\gamma\delta$ T cell identity

To assess the transcriptomic impact of HEB deficiency, we performed single-cell RNA sequencing (scRNA-seq) on $\gamma\delta$ TCR⁺ thymocytes sorted from E18 WT and HEB cKO littermates. After quality control, we merged the datasets, excluded myeloid cells, and regressed out cell cycle genes using Seurat ([46](#) [43](#)). Our analysis identified eight distinct clusters (numbered 0 to 7) visualized as a UMAP (**Fig. 2A** [43](#)). WT cells were enriched in clusters 2 and 4, while HEB cKO cells dominated clusters 0, 1, and 3. Clusters 5–7 showed a more balanced distribution (**Fig. 2B, C** [43](#)). To annotate the clusters, we curated 90 $\gamma\delta$ T cell subset-defining genes from prior studies ([13](#) [43](#), [21](#) [43](#), [47](#) [43](#)–[51](#) [43](#)) (**Suppl. Table 1** [43](#)). The top 10 differentially expressed genes were used to generate a clustered dot plot (**Fig. 2D** [43](#)), which we used to identify each cluster. We classified clusters 2 and 6 as early $\gamma\delta$ T cells ($\gamma\delta$ Te1, $\gamma\delta$ Te2), clusters 1 and 4 as $\gamma\delta$ T17 progenitors ($\gamma\delta$ T17p), cluster 0 as $\gamma\delta$ T1 progenitors ($\gamma\delta$ T1p), cluster 7 as mature $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells ($\gamma\delta$ T1), cluster 5 as mature $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells ($\gamma\delta$ T17), and cluster 3 as $\alpha\beta$ lineage-like cells ($\alpha\beta$ T).

Quantification of WT and HEB cKO cells per cluster (**Fig. 2E** [43](#)) revealed that the $\gamma\delta$ T17p clusters segregated by genotype into WT ($\gamma\delta$ T17pw) and HEB cKO ($\gamma\delta$ T17pk) cells. HEB cKO cells were also over-represented in the $\alpha\beta$ T cluster and under-represented in the $\gamma\delta$ Te1 cluster. An unbiased heatmap of the top 10 most differentially expressed genes across all clusters further validated our assigned identities, and revealed additional genes associated with these subsets (**Fig. 2F** [43](#)). These findings suggest that the loss of HEB impairs the early $\gamma\delta$ T cell program and allows diversion toward the $\alpha\beta$ T cell lineage.

HEB deficiency suppresses TRDV5 expression and promotes TRDV4 expression

We next confirmed that WT and HEB cKO cells within each cluster represented equivalent developmental subsets (**Suppl. Fig. 2A** [43](#)). All immature $\gamma\delta$ T cell clusters expressed *Cd24a* and *Cd27*, while mature subsets lacked *Cd24a*. Among mature cells, only $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells expressed *Cd27* and *Nt5e* (CD73), whereas $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells were uniquely *Cd44*-positive, consistent with our assignments. We also analyzed TRGV and TRDV gene expression (**Suppl. Fig. 2B, C** [43](#)). In WT cells, TRGV4 and TRDV5 were co-expressed in $\gamma\delta$ Te and $\gamma\delta$ T17p populations but were greatly diminished in HEB cKO cells. TRGV6 and TRGV5 transcripts were detectable in $\gamma\delta$ Te subsets from HEB cKO mice, consistent with a delay in V γ 6⁺ and V γ 5⁺ $\gamma\delta$ T cell maturation (**Fig. 1K** [43](#)), whereas TRDV4 was expressed more broadly and at higher levels in all immature HEB cKO $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets relative to WT counterparts. These results indicate that HEB plays an important role in maintaining the subset-specific and magnitude of TRGV5 and TRDV4 expression during $\gamma\delta$ T cell development.

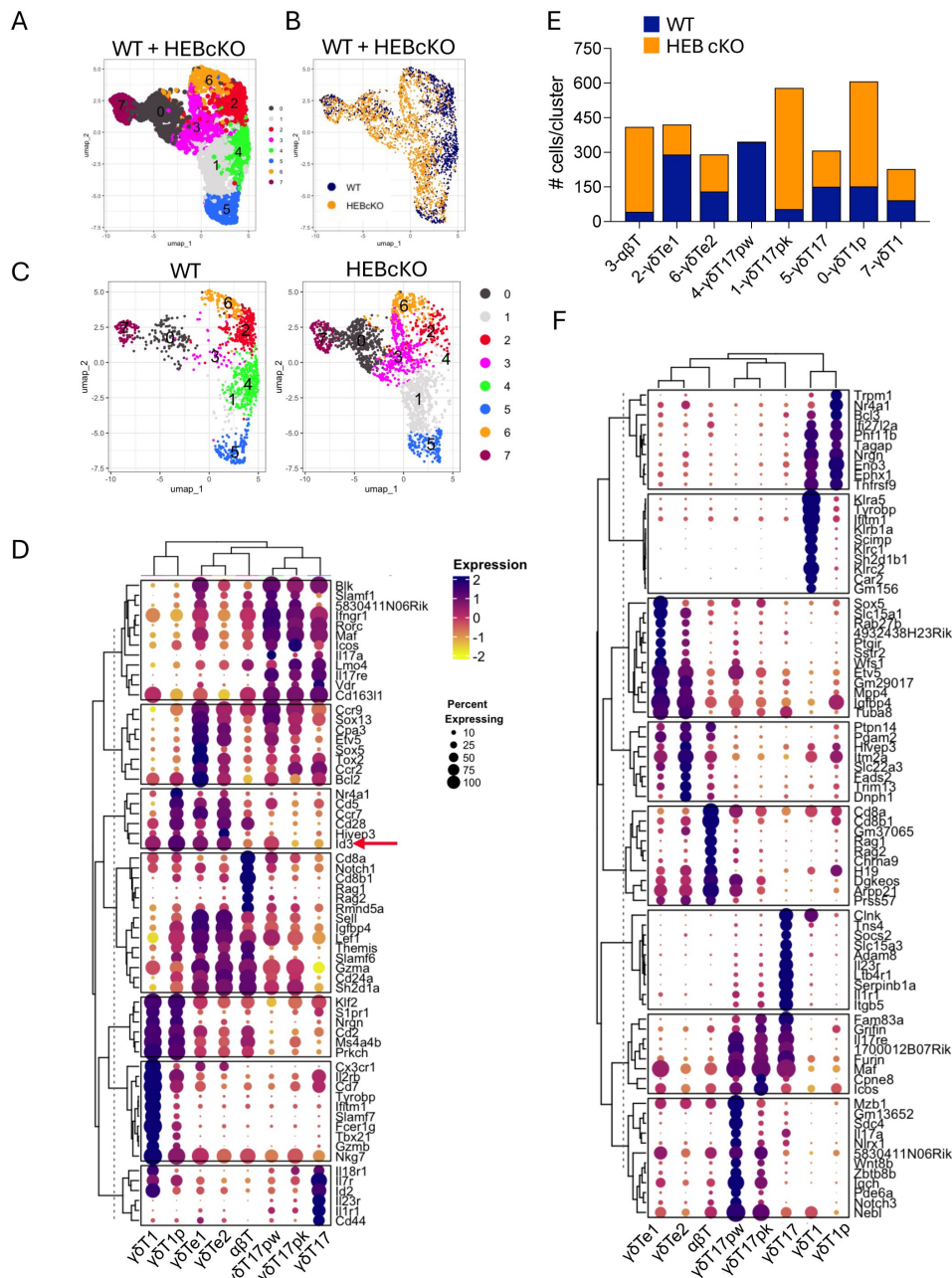


Figure 2.

Identification of $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets in WT and HEB cKO fetal thymus by scRNA-seq.

$\gamma\delta$ T cells were sorted from E18 fetal thymuses from WT and HEB cKO mice, pooled according to genotype, and subjected to scRNA-sequencing and analysis. A. UMAP plots depicting merged WT and HEB cKO cells in 8 clusters (0-7). B. Grouped UMAP showing the distribution of WT (blue) and HEB cKO (orange) cells across all clusters. C. Split UMAP plots showing the distribution of cells in WT (left) and HEB cKO (right) clusters; note that cluster 4 is restricted to WT cells, and cluster 1 is heavily biased towards HEB cKO cells. D. Genes previously identified as signatures for developmental and functional $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets were compiled from previously published reports. The top ten most differentially expressed genes from this list were visualized as a clustered dot plot which was used to assign cluster identities. Two clusters corresponding to early $\gamma\delta$ T cells ($\gamma\delta$ Te) were randomly named $\gamma\delta$ Te1 and $\gamma\delta$ Te2. E. Numbers of WT (blue) and HEB cKO (orange) cells per cluster. F. Unbiased clustered dot plot of the top ten most differentially expressed genes across all clusters. In the clustered dot plots, the percentage of cells expressing the gene in each cluster is depicted by the size of the dot, and the color indicates the relative magnitude of expression across clusters.

HEB deficiency impairs early $\gamma\delta$ T cell signatures and enhances $\alpha\beta$ -T lineage features

To further define differences between WT and HEB cKO cells at the transcriptomic level, we constructed gene modules composed of suites of signature genes for the $\gamma\delta$ Te1, $\gamma\delta$ Te2, $\alpha\beta$ T, $\gamma\delta$ T17p, $\gamma\delta$ T17, $\gamma\delta$ T1p, and $\gamma\delta$ T1 subsets, derived from the analysis of merged WT and HEB cKO cells (**Fig. 2D, F**; see Methods). These modules were used to assign scores in WT (left) and HEB cKO (right) cells, which were visualized using split dot plots.

This analysis revealed a pronounced loss of the $\gamma\delta$ Te1 gene signature in HEB cKO cells (**Fig. 3A**) alongside a notable increase in the $\alpha\beta$ T signature (**Fig. 3B**). The $\gamma\delta$ Te2, $\gamma\delta$ T17p, and $\gamma\delta$ T17 gene signatures were also diminished in HEB cKO cells relative to WT, whereas the $\gamma\delta$ T1p signature was enriched. We also examined expression of individual genes that were diagnostic for $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets. In the $\gamma\delta$ Te1 and $\gamma\delta$ Te2 subsets of HEB cKO mice, *Sox13* and *Etv5* were reduced and *Cd8b1* and *Dgkeos* were elevated relative to their WT counterparts (**Fig. 3D**). In $\gamma\delta$ T17p cells, $\alpha\beta$ T-lineage genes were not detectable, but *Sox13* and *Etv5* were still lower in HEB cKO cells than WT cells, potentially decoupling the specification and commitment events. A less dramatic reduction in *Il1r1* was observed in HEB cKO $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells (**Fig. 3E**), and the levels of *Nrgn* and *Eomes* were similar in $\gamma\delta$ T1 lineage cells (**Fig. 3F**). These results suggest that the impact of HEB deficiency at the transcriptomic level was more pronounced in early $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets than in mature $\gamma\delta$ T cells.

HEB deficiency obstructs $\gamma\delta$ T17 progenitor development and dampens TCR signal strength

The $\gamma\delta$ T17p subset segregated into distinct clusters in WT and HEB cKO cells, highlighting a critical stage of HEB-dependent regulation. To explore this further, we performed an unbiased differential gene expression analysis in WT cells versus HEB cKO cells and visualized the results using an enhanced volcano plot with stringent thresholds ($\log_2FC > 0.5$, $-\log_{10}P > 25$) (**Fig. 4A**). Many of the top differentially expressed genes were signature markers of $\gamma\delta$ T17 differentiation, including *Blk*, *Sox13*, and *Etv5*, all of which were downregulated in HEB cKO cells. *Trdv4* was among the most upregulated genes in HEB cKO $\gamma\delta$ T17p cells.

We next generated a list of differentially expressed genes between WT and HEB cKO $\gamma\delta$ T17p cells using less stringent criteria (adj P value > 0.001 , $\log_2Fc > 0.25$) (**Suppl. Table 2**). This list was subjected to gene ontology analysis using ShinyGO, which resulted in a list of KEGG pathways with reduced gene representation in HEB cKO $\gamma\delta$ T17p cells. We observed significant depletion of genes pathways related to TCR signaling (T cell receptor signaling, PD-1 checkpoint, NF- κ B signaling) and Th1, Th2, and Th17 differentiation in HEB cKO cells relative to WT cells (**Fig. 4B**; **Suppl. Table 3**). Three key markers of TCR signal strength, *Cd5*, *Cd69*, and *Egr1*, were reduced in both $\gamma\delta$ Te2 and $\gamma\delta$ T17p subsets in HEB cKO mice (**Fig. 4C**). *Id3* expression was markedly decreased in HEB cKO $\gamma\delta$ Te cells and nearly absent in $\gamma\delta$ T17p cells but remained intact in $\gamma\delta$ T1p and $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells (**Fig. 4D, E**). We also examined the expression *Maf* and *Rorc*, two key regulators of $\gamma\delta$ T17 maturation, and found that they were expressed similarly between HEB cKO and WT cells in each cluster (**Fig. 4F**). Therefore, HEB modulates TCR signaling during $\gamma\delta$ T17 specification but appears to be dispensable for the expression of $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell maturation factors.

Id3 expression in $\gamma\delta$ T17 progenitors is controlled through HEB-dependent mechanisms

To further elucidate the landscape of E protein and Id protein expression during $\gamma\delta$ T cell development, we examined the expression of *Tcf12* (encodes HEB), *Tcf3* (encodes E2A), *Id3*, and *Id2* in each cluster (**Suppl. Fig. 3**). It should be noted that the *Tcf12* deletion occurs in one of the last

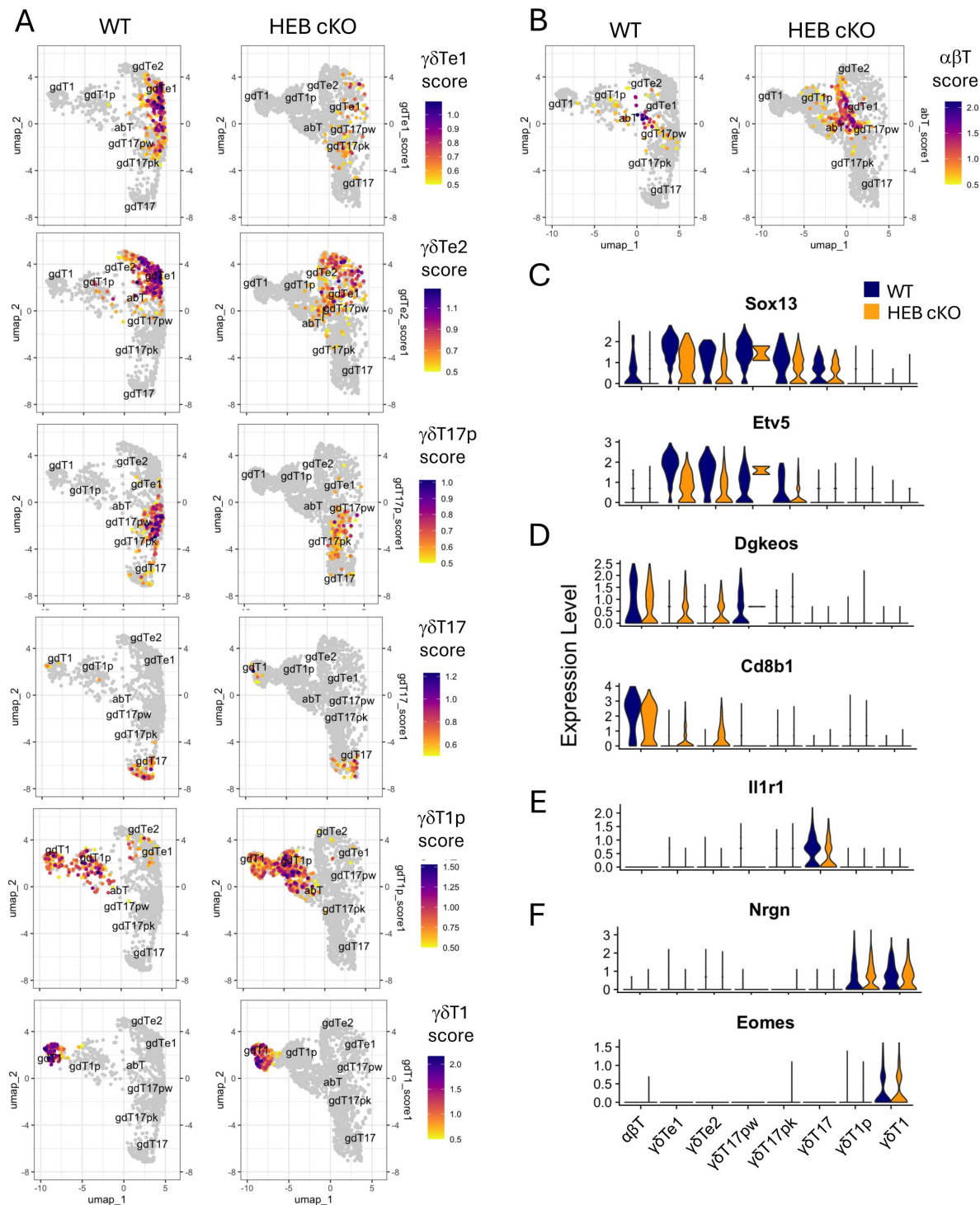


Figure 3.

The $\alpha\beta$ T gene program is inflated and the $\gamma\delta$ T17 precursor gene program is lost in HEB cKO cells.

$\gamma\delta$ T cells were sorted from E18 fetal thymuses from WT and HEB cKO mice were pooled according to genotype and subjected to scRNA-sequencing and analysis. A, B. Gene modules were generated from subset-biased genes (Fig. 2), and cells were scored for each module. Module scores are depicted as split feature plots, with WT plots on the left and HEB cKO plots on the right. Module scores that characterize $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets are shown in (A), and a module score for the $\alpha\beta$ -T lineage is shown in (B). C-G. Split violin plots of genes that typify different $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets as follows: C) $\gamma\delta$ Te/ $\gamma\delta$ T17p cells, (D) $\alpha\beta$ T cells, (E) $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells, (F) $\gamma\delta$ T1p/ $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells, and (G) $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells. Blue = WT, orange = HEB cKO.

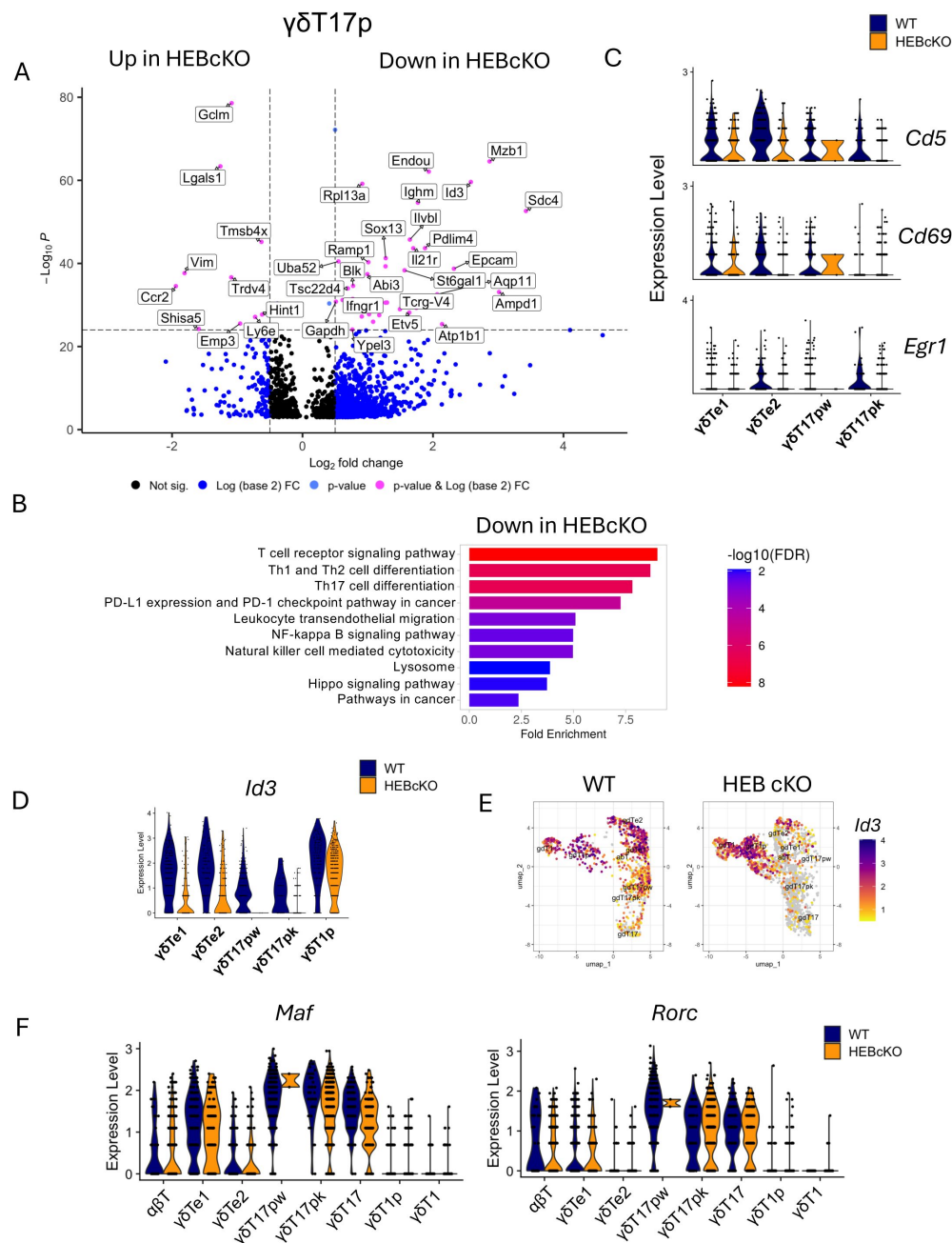


Figure 4.

Decreases in T cell effector differentiation and TCR signaling genes in $\gamma\delta T17p$ cells from HEB cKO mice.

A. Volcano plots showing differential gene expression in $\gamma\delta T17p$ cells from WT versus HEB cKO fetal thymus. Genes expressed at higher levels in HEB cKO cells are on the left, and genes expressed at lower levels in HEB cKO cells are on the right. Significance (pink) was set at $\text{Log}_2\text{Fc} > 0.5$ and $\text{Log}_{10}P < 10^{-25}$. B. Gene ontology analysis of genes significantly reduced in HEB cKO $\gamma\delta T17p$ cells relative to WT, with significance set at avg $\text{Log}_2\text{Fc} > 0.25$ and adjusted P value < 0.001 . Bar plots show pathway enrichment (Fold enrichment) and significance by false discovery rate (FDR) for each functional category defined in the KEGG pathway list. Minimum genes for pathway inclusion was set at 5 and FDR cutoff was set at 0.05. C. Relative expression of genes associated with strong TCR signaling in WT and HEB cKO cells in each cluster. D. Relative expression of *Id3* in immature $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets from WT and HEB cKO mice. E. Split feature plots showing expression of *Id3* across all clusters in WT versus HEB cKO cells. F. Relative expression of *Maf* and *Rorc* in WT versus HEB cKO $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets. WT = blue, HEB cKO = orange.

exons of a 200 kb gene locus, and although the protein is absent (44), some mRNA expression can still be detected. In WT mice, $\gamma\delta$ Te cells co-expressed *Tcf12*, *Tcf3*, and *Id3* (Suppl. Fig. 3A-C, E), consistent with dynamic regulation of E protein-dependent target genes expression during the $\alpha\beta/\gamma\delta$ fate choice (52). $\gamma\delta$ T17p cells co-expressed *Tcf12* and *Tcf3*, whereas $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells co-expressed *Tcf3* and *Id3* (Suppl. Fig. 3B, D). *Id2* expression was restricted to mature $\gamma\delta$ T17 and mature $\gamma\delta$ T1 cells in both WT and HEB cKO mice. *Tcf3* expression was also unaffected by a lack of HEB, indicating that *Tcf3* and *Id2* expression are HEB-independent (Suppl. Fig. 3E, F). *Id3* expression was disrupted in HEB cKO cells in $\gamma\delta$ Te and $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells but not in $\gamma\delta$ T1p cells (Suppl. Fig. 3C, D). This analysis reveals that *Id3* expression was disrupted only in cells that normally express *Tcf12*.

Loss of *Id3* impairs CD73 upregulation and $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell function in the fetal thymus

Given the clear dependence of *Id3* expression on HEB in specific $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets, we next investigated how loss of *Id3* itself affects $\gamma\delta$ T cell development using E18 fetal thymocytes from *Id3* knockout (*Id3*-KO) mice. Total thymic cellularity in *Id3*-KO mice was comparable to WT controls (Fig. 5A), but the proportion of $\gamma\delta$ T cells among total thymocytes was reduced (Fig. 5B, C). Analysis of V γ chain usage revealed no major differences between WT and *Id3*-KO mice, although there was a slight increase in the proportion of V γ 6⁺ cells in *Id3*-KO $\gamma\delta$ T cells (Fig. 5F). Interestingly, very few *Id3*-KO $\gamma\delta$ T cells expressed CD73 (encoded by *Nt5e*) (Fig. 5G, H), including V γ 5⁺ and V γ 1⁺ cells (Suppl. Fig. 4). *Nt5e* expression is upregulated in response to strong TCR signaling during $\gamma\delta$ T cell development, and it can also be induced in response to short-term stimulation (53, 54). To determine whether the deficiency in CD73 expression in *Id3*-KO mice reflected an expansion of CD73⁺ cells or a failure to induce *Nt5e*, we cultured E18 fetal thymocytes from WT and *Id3*-KO mice with PMA/ionomycin (P/I) for four hours and measured CD73 expression in $\gamma\delta$ T cells by flow cytometry. While CD73 was robustly induced in a substantial fraction of CD27⁺ $\gamma\delta$ T cells from WT mice, it remained nearly undetectable in *Id3*-KO $\gamma\delta$ T cells (Fig. 5I, J), indicating a direct role for *Id3* in the regulation of *Nt5e* expression.

Mature CD73⁺ $\gamma\delta$ T cells typically exhibit a bias toward the $\gamma\delta$ T17 lineage (8). We hypothesized that loss of *Id3* might re-direct $\gamma\delta$ T1-fated cells into the $\gamma\delta$ T17 lineage. However, upon stimulation, *Id3*-KO $\gamma\delta$ T cells failed to produce IL-17 (Fig. 5K, L), indicating that *Id3* deficiency does not promote $\gamma\delta$ T17 differentiation. These findings highlight a critical role for *Id3* in the functional maturation of both CD73⁺ and CD73⁺ $\gamma\delta$ T cells.

Loss of *Id3* disrupts expression of $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell maturation transcription factors

To further investigate how *Id3* deficiency affects $\gamma\delta$ T cell development, we measured intracellular expression of PLZF (encoded by *Zbtb16*) and MAF in E18 $\gamma\delta$ T cells from WT and *Id3*-KO mice by flow cytometry (Fig. 6). PLZF is expressed in innate fetal/neonatal $\gamma\delta$ T cells and adult iNKT and IL-4-producing $\gamma\delta$ T cells (55–57). To compare developmental stages within V γ subsets between WT and *Id3*-KO $\gamma\delta$ T cells, we gated on: 1) immature (CD24⁺) V γ 4 cells, which comprised the majority of V γ 4 cells, 2) immature (CD24⁺) V γ 6 cells, and 3) mature (CD24⁺) V γ 6 cells (Fig. 6A). This analysis yielded three populations, based on PLZF and MAF expression: PLZF⁺MAF⁺, PLZF⁺MAF[−], and PLZF[−]MAF[−] cells (Fig. 6B).

In WT mice, most immature V γ 4 and V γ 6 cells expressed PLZF, with about half of the PLZF⁺ cells co-expressing MAF. Nearly all mature V γ 6 cells co-expressed PLZF and MAF. Immature V γ 4 and V γ 6 subsets in *Id3*-KO mice had reduced proportions of PLZF⁺MAF⁺ cell proportions and increased percentages of PLZF[−]MAF[−] cells relative to WT. Mature V γ 6 cells in *Id3*-KO mice exhibited a more severe disruption, with only ~50% co-expressing PLZF and MAF, and significant increases within

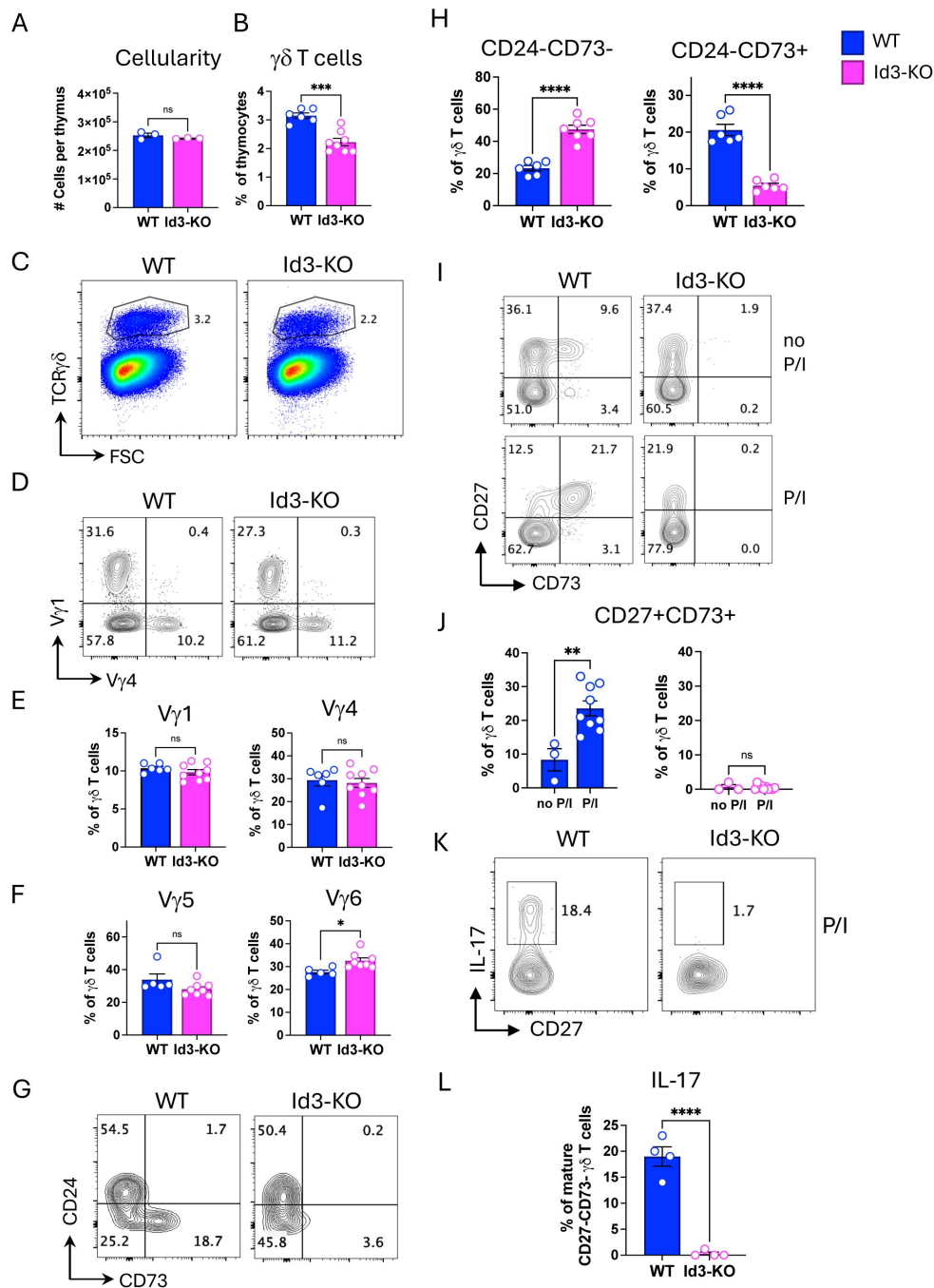


Figure 5.

Fetal $\gamma\delta$ T cells from Id3-KO mice are defective in CD73 upregulation and IL-17 production.

A. Absolute numbers of cells per E18 fetal thymus from WT and Id3-KO littermate mice. B, C. Quantification (B) and flow cytometry plots (C) of the percentages of $\gamma\delta$ T cells out of all thymocytes. D, E. Flow cytometry plots (D) and quantification (E) of $V\gamma1^+$ and $V\gamma4^+$ out of all $\gamma\delta$ T cells. F. Percentages of $V\gamma5^+$ and $V\gamma6^+$ out of all $\gamma\delta$ T cells. G. Flow cytometry plots of CD24 and CD73 expression in $\gamma\delta TCR^+$ cells. H. Quantification of mature ($CD24^-$) $CD73^+$ and $CD73^-$ $\gamma\delta$ T cells out of all $\gamma\delta$ T cells. I. Flow cytometry plots of expression of CD27 and CD73 expression in unstimulated (top) and stimulated (bottom) $\gamma\delta$ T cells. J. Percentages of $CD27^+CD73^+$ cells out of all $\gamma\delta$ T cells under unstimulated or stimulated conditions. K, L. Flow cytometry (K) and quantification (L) of the percentages of $CD27^-CD73^-CD24^-$ (primarily mature $V\gamma6$) cells expressing IL-17 in response to stimulation. Blue = WT, pink = Id3-KO. P/I = phorbol 12-myristate 13-acetate (PMA) + ionomycin. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$, **** $p < 0.0001$.

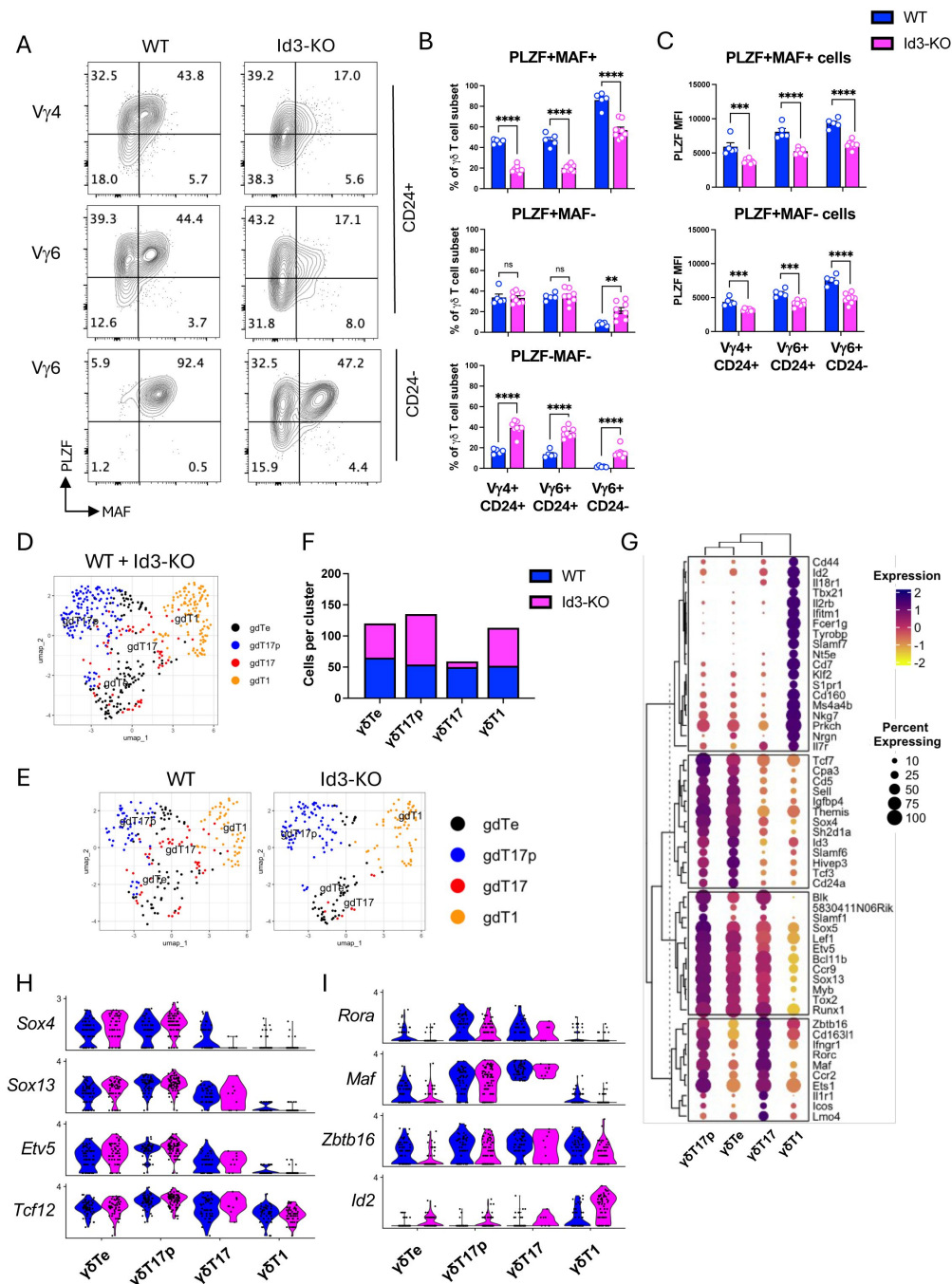


Figure 6.

Intact $\gamma\delta$ T commitment gene program and impaired $\gamma\delta$ T17 maturation program in Id3-KO mice.

A. Flow cytometry plots showing the percentages of cells expressing PLZF and/or MAF in immature (CD24⁺) V γ 4 and V γ 6 cells, and in mature (CD24⁻) V γ 6 cells (note that mature V γ 4 cells are not present in the E18 fetal thymus). B. Quantification of the percentages of cells expressing PLZF and MAF (top), PLZF only (middle) or neither (bottom) within the immature V γ 4 and V γ 6 subsets, and the mature V γ 6 subset. C. Mean fluorescent intensities of PLZF in the PLZF⁺MAF⁺ and PLZF⁺MAF⁻ populations within the immature and mature V γ subsets. D, E. sRNA-seq UMAP plots of $\gamma\delta$ T cells as merged (D) or split (E) into WT versus Id3-KO populations. F. Number of WT and Id3-KO cells per cluster. G. Clustered dot plot of curated gene sets used to assign $\gamma\delta$ T17p, $\gamma\delta$ Te, $\gamma\delta$ T17, and $\gamma\delta$ T1 identities. H. Expression of $\gamma\delta$ T cell commitment genes in WT versus Id3-KO cells by cluster. I. Expression of $\gamma\delta$ T17 maturation genes in WT versus Id3-KO cells by cluster. Blue = WT, pink = Id3-KO. ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001, **** p < 0.0001

the PLZF⁺MAF⁺ or PLZF⁺MAF⁻ subsets. Mean fluorescence intensity analysis revealed substantially lower PLZF protein levels in Id3-KO cells across all subsets, especially immature cells, suggesting that this defect is not solely due to delayed maturation (Fig. 6C).

Id3 deficiency promotes the αβ-T lineage but does not disrupt the expression of early γδ T cell regulators. To investigate population dynamics and gene expression changes in Id3-KO fetal thymocytes, we performed scRNA-seq on CD4⁺CD8⁺ E18 fetal thymocytes. This strategy was designed to capture γδ T-biased cells with low surface γδTCR that might be missed by flow cytometric cell sorting. After quality control, WT and Id3-KO datasets were merged and subjected to dimensionality reduction, which identified eleven clusters (0–10) (Suppl. Fig. 5). Violin plots of lineage and subset-specific genes identified two γδ T cell clusters, which were computationally isolated and reclustered. This process yielded four new γδ T cell clusters (0–3), which we identified as γδTe, γδT17p, γδT17, and γδT1 cells (Fig. 6D, E), using the same strategy shown in Fig. 2 (Fig. 6G). This scRNA-seq dataset lacked a γδ/αβ T lineage cluster, likely due to low cell numbers and/or exclusion of CD4⁺ and CD8⁺ cells in the enrichment strategy. However, flow cytometry of E18 fetal thymocytes revealed a significantly higher proportion of TCRγδ⁺ cells co-expressing CD4 and CD8 in Id3-KO mice than in WT mice, indicating a bias toward the αβ T cell program (Suppl. Fig. 6). Notably, our scRNA-seq analysis showed that γδ T cell specification genes (*Sox13*, *Etv5*) and *Tcf12* were unaffected by the decrease in *Id3* (Fig. 6H). These results decouple the loss of *Id3* from the disruption of early γδ T cell regulators in HEB cKO mice.

***Id3* is required for the induction of γδT17 regulators at the transcriptional level**

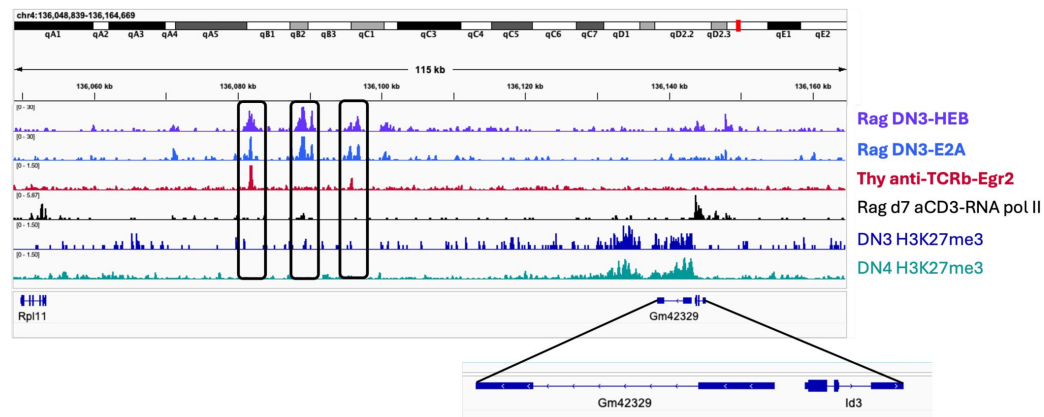
Compared to WT, the Id3-KO mice had increased numbers of γδT17p cells and fewer mature γδT17 cells (Fig. 6F), consistent with a partial block in γδT17 maturation. *Id2* expression was markedly increased in all Id3-KO γδ T cell subsets (Fig. 6I), consistent with a previously reported compensatory role (58). *Maf* and *Zbtb16* transcripts were markedly reduced in Id3-KO cells at the γδTe stage but recovered to near WT levels in mature γδT17 cells (Fig. 6I). We noted a similar impact on expression of *Rora* in Id3-KO mice. *Rora* is not required for γδT17 cell function (59), but does play roles in regulation the development of Th17 (60) and ILC3 cells (61). We also examined expression of *Rorc* (encodes RORγt). Given the decrease in other genes involved in γδT17 cell maturation, and the dependence of *Rorc* expression on MAF in γδT17 cells (22), we were surprised to find that *Rorc* was higher in Id3-KO γδT17p cells than in WT γδT17p cells (Suppl. Fig. 5D) and was also elevated in the CD8-expressing DN4 subset (Suppl. Fig. 5E). Although RORγt is a critical regulator of γδT17 development and function, it is also upregulated after β-selection and maintains DP cell survival (62), suggesting that the increase we observed in the γδT17p cells could in part be due to αβ-T cell lineage diversion.

ChIP-Seq analysis reveals shared HEB, E2A, and Egr2 binding sites in the *Id3* locus

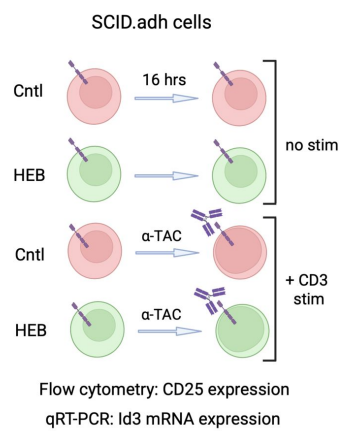
Although our data showed that HEB is necessary for *Id3* expression during γδT17 development, it remained unclear whether HEB directly regulates *Id3*. The *Id3* gene locus is composed of three exons adjacent to the long non-coding RNA gene *Gm42329*, which lies in the opposite (tail-to-tail) orientation (Fig. 7A). To assess direct binding of HEB and/or E2A to the *Id3* locus, we analyzed ChIP-seq datasets from *Rag2*^{-/-} DN3 thymocytes (63). This analysis identified three major binding regions for both HEB and E2A upstream of the first exon of *Id3*, each containing multiple peaks.

We also examined ChIP-seq datasets from DN3 cells stimulated with anti-CD3 or anti-TCRβ to mimic TCR signaling (64, 65). RNA polymerase II bound the *Id3* promoter in *Rag2*^{-/-} mice stimulated with anti-CD3, revealing active *Id3* transcription in cells that had experienced CD3-mediated signaling. Additionally, we observed Egr2 binding to two sites that overlapped with the HEB/E2A regions in total thymocytes from mice that had been injected with anti-TCRβ (64).

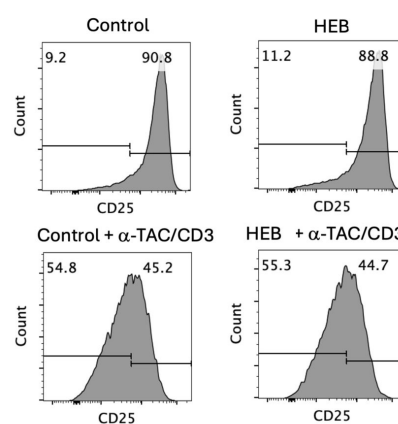
A



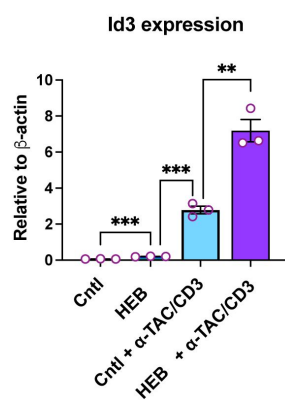
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C



D



E

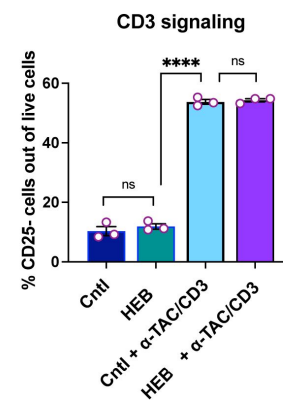


Figure 7.

Synergistic upregulation of *Id3* by HEB and CD3 signaling.

A. ChIP-seq data analysis of the binding of HEB, E2A, RNA polymerase, and Egr2, and the extent of H3K27me3 chromatin modification, in DN3 and/or DN4 cells at the *Id3* gene locus, obtained from publicly available datasets (see Materials and Methods for accession numbers). The cell type and antibody used in each experiment are indicated to the right of the tracks. Peaks bound by HEB, E2A, and/or Egr2 are indicated in boxes. Inset shows the *Id3* exons and the adjacent *Gm42329* long non-coding RNA. B. Diagram of experimental design. SCID.adh cells transduced with HEBAlt or control retroviral vectors were cultured for 16 hours in the presence or absence of the anti-TAC antibody, which induces signaling through the CD3 complex. C, E. Flow cytometry plots (C) and quantification (E) of CD25 upregulation with and without stimulation and/or HEB expression. D. *Id3* mRNA expression relative to β -actin as determined by quantitative RT-PCR. Rag = *Rag2*^{-/-} mouse thymocytes, which are arrested at the DN3 stage of development. ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$, **** $p < 0.0001$

Notably, H3K27me3 repressive marks were detected across the *Gm42329* locus but were absent from *Id3*, indicating that *Id3* is epigenetically poised for activation before pre-TCR and/or $\gamma\delta$ TCR signaling occurs.

Together, these data suggest that *Id3* is a direct transcriptional target of HEB and E2A and that its induction in response to TCR signaling depends on the combined action of HEB, E2A, and Egr2 during the DN3 to DN4 transition.

TCR Signaling and HEB Converge to Potentiate *Id3* Transcription

To test whether HEB can cooperate with TCR/CD3 signaling to upregulate *Id3*, we used a gain-of-function approach. We took advantage of the SCID.adh cell line, which ectopically expresses a chimeric hIL-2R α :CD3 ϵ receptor that mimics pre-TCR signaling when stimulated with anti-TAC (hIL-2R α) antibody (66). Stimulation results in downregulation of CD25, *Rag1*, *Rag2*, and *Ptcra*, while inducing *Trac* germline transcripts, recapitulating pre-TCR activity.

We transduced SCID.adh cells with either control or HEB-expressing retroviruses to generate control and HEB-overexpressing cells (Fig. 7B). To avoid the growth arrest and cell death associated with full-length HEB (HEBCan) overexpression (67, 68), we used HEBAlt, a truncated form that activates E protein target genes without impairing cell viability (68–70).

Upon overnight stimulation with anti-TAC, both control and HEB-expressing cells downregulated CD25 to similar degrees, as assessed by flow cytometry, confirming effective CD3-mediated signaling (Fig. 7C, E). Quantitative RT-PCR analysis showed that *Id3* expression was modestly elevated in unstimulated HEB-expressing cells compared to controls, and stimulation of control cells upregulated *Id3* levels to a greater degree (Fig. 7D). Notably, *Id3* expression in stimulated cells expressing HEB was much higher than either HEB or stimulation alone, and exceeded the sum of these two conditions, indicating a synergistic interaction.

These results demonstrate that HEB can amplify *Id3* induction in response to TCR signaling, likely through cooperative interaction with TCR-induced factors such as Egr2.

Discussion

HEB and *Id3* are both critical for T cell development, but their distinct functions in fetal $\gamma\delta$ T cell development have not been resolved. Here, we show that HEB controls expression of genes involved in $\gamma\delta$ TCR signaling and induces a transcriptional program that primes $\gamma\delta$ T cell precursors for $\gamma\delta$ T17 differentiation. Furthermore, HEB collaborates with TCR-dependent factors such as Egr2 to upregulate *Id3*, which enables $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell maturation and inhibits the $\alpha\beta$ T cell fate. Together, these findings define a sequence of regulatory states governed by the E/*Id* axis that orchestrate $\gamma\delta$ T cell lineage commitment and the differentiation of functional $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells.

TCR signal strength is tightly linked to specific combinations of V γ and V δ chains expressed on fetal $\gamma\delta$ T cells, which serve as critical drivers of $\gamma\delta$ T cell fate and functional programming (12, 32, 34, 71). We found that HEB is required for expression of TRGV4 and TRDV5. These genes encode the V γ 4⁺V δ 5⁺ TCR, which supports $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell differentiation (72). While TRGV4 is known to be regulated by E proteins (8, 73, 74), the requirement for HEB in TRDV5 expression is newly appreciated. Notably, the TRD locus contains E2A-dependent insulators that limit TRDV4 expression to the fetal thymus (75). Whether these are also HEB-dependent, and whether they impact TRDV expression among fetal $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets, remains to be determined.

Our analysis identified known E protein target genes, including components of the TCR signaling pathway (*Cd3d*, *Cd3g*, *Lat*, *Zap70*) (76 [↗](#), 77 [↗](#)) and chemokine receptors (*Cxcr5*, *Cxcr4*, *Ccr9*) (78 [↗](#)), validating the experimental approach. Moreover, we found that a suite of $\gamma\delta$ T17-specific genes were also HEB-dependent, including *Blk* and *Syk*, which are $\gamma\delta$ T17 cell-specific mediators of TCR signaling. We also noted that several inhibitors of TCR signaling were decreased, including *Pdcd1* (encodes PD-1), *Nfbia* (encodes Ikappa α), and *Sh2d2a* (encodes TSAd). All of these inhibitors are regulated post-translationally, suggesting a role for HEB in inducing T-lineage specific pathways that enable both positive and negative regulation of TCR signal transduction.

Our studies show that Id3 limits $\alpha\beta$ -lineage potential even in the presence of HEB, suggesting that HEB restricts the $\alpha\beta$ program primarily by upregulating *Id3*. In contrast, the early $\gamma\delta$ T cell program is upregulated in Id3-KO mice, indicating that *Id3* is not required for this function. A third E/Id dynamic operates during $\gamma\delta$ T17 maturation, which requires *Id3* independently of HEB. Sox13 has been shown to initiate a cascade of regulatory events that induce *Blk* and *Maf* during $\gamma\delta$ T17 development (8 [↗](#), 21 [↗](#)). However, our work indicates that Sox13 is not sufficient to upregulate $\gamma\delta$ T17 maturation factors like *Zbtb16* and *Maf* in the absence of *Id3*, implying an E-protein dependent brake on $\gamma\delta$ T17 maturation. This highlights a decoupling between lineage specification and effector maturation, supporting the two-step model of $\gamma\delta$ T cell development (54 [↗](#)).

Intriguingly, our results show that $\gamma\delta$ T1 lineage cells express *Tcf3* (E2A) but not *Tcf12* (HEB), consistent with an HEB-independent $\gamma\delta$ T1 gene regulatory network. It is possible that Id3 is needed after gd T cell specification to inhibit E2A-driven inhibitors of $\gamma\delta$ T17 maturation. Possible candidates include positive regulators of $\gamma\delta$ T1 differentiation, such as T-bet (*Tbx21*) or Eomes. These transcription factors participate in negative cross-regulatory loops with $\gamma\delta$ T17 regulators such as Runx1, ROR γ t, and AP-1 factors, which help to stabilize $\gamma\delta$ T cell subset lineage identity (79 [↗](#)). Additionally, transiently expressed HEB-dependent transcription factors such as *Etv5* and *Sox5* may act as a checkpoint for $\gamma\delta$ T17 maturation, to be released upon *Id3* upregulation.

The TCR signal strength model posits that strong signals induce high levels of Egr factors, which induce high levels of *Id3* (25 [↗](#), 39 [↗](#)). Our data add an important new dimension to this paradigm, proposing that the lower Egr2 levels induced by weaker $\gamma\delta$ TCR signaling require cooperation with

HEB/E2A to upregulate *Id3* expression (Suppl. Fig. 7A [↗](#)). This model is supported by our ChIP-seq data, which confirms HEB and E2A binding at the *Id3* locus, at sites also bound by Egr2, and gain-of-function studies, which show that HEB synergizes with TCR/CD3 signals to amplify *Id3* expression. Both HEB and E2A are pioneering factors, and can increase locus accessibility of genes involved in lymphoid development, such as *Foxo1* (43 [↗](#)). Therefore, HEB and E2A may epigenetically prime the *Id3* locus prior to TCR signaling.

Our data is consistent with a partial compensation for Id3 by Id2, less effectively during $\gamma\delta$ T cell commitment, and more fully during late $\gamma\delta$ T17 maturation, when *Id2* is normally expressed. This is consistent with the observation that Id3 supports transient developmental transitions, while Id2 stabilizes innate-like transcriptional states (80 [↗](#)). Since *Id2* is a direct target of E2A (81 [↗](#)), the upregulation of *Id2* in *Id3*-deficient precursors likely reflects increased E protein activity. Thus, HEB, Id3, and Id2 participate in negative regulatory loops that allow transient HEB activity and Id3 expression, followed by stabilization of the innate $\gamma\delta$ T17 gene network by Id2 (Suppl. Fig. 7B [↗](#)). Understanding how Id3 and Id2 differentially regulate the timing and magnitude of E protein activity, and whether they have different impacts on E2A/E2A homodimers versus HEB/E2A heterodimers remains to be addressed.

There are limitations to our study. Our analyses focused on E18 $\gamma\delta$ T cells, which reflect $\gamma\delta$ T17-biased fetal development and may not capture functions of HEB or Id3 at other stages. It is also unclear whether diminished PLZF and MAF expression reflects a cause or consequence of

inhibited maturation. The specific contributions of HEB^{Alt} and HEB^{Can} isoforms remain unresolved, as both were deleted in our conditional HEB model. In addition, we have not yet addressed the roles of HEB and Id3 in TCR-independent development of a subset of fetal-derived V γ 4⁺ γ δ T cells (48 [DOI](#)).

In summary, our studies have identified multiple interlinked transcriptional circuits that require E proteins and Id factors during γ δ T cell development. HEB induces Id3, which then inhibits E protein activity. In the absence of Id3, HEB and E2A activity persist, inducing compensatory Id2 expression. Since Id3 expression is self-limiting through E protein suppression, the HEB-Id3 interactions result in a negative feedback loop. Thus, HEB plays dual roles in establishing γ δ lineage identity and initiating γ δ T17 differentiation via Id3. Future work should clarify the direct transcriptional targets and co-factors of HEB, as well as how dynamic levels of HEB, Id3, and Id2 coordinate γ δ T cell fate decisions.

Materials and methods

Experimental Design and Statistical Analysis

The overall goal of this study was to understand how HEB transcription factors regulate the transcriptional networks required for the development of IL-17 producing γ δ T cells. The subjects of these studies were genetically modified mice. The experimental variable was the genotype of the mice, chosen based on availability of animals and littermate controls. For the scRNA-seq experiments, fetal thymocytes of like genotype from 3 or more mice were pooled prior to enrichment. Each flow cytometry analysis was performed using 3 or more mice of like genotype per experiment, repeated 2-3 times. Mice of both sexes were used. No sex differences were apparent; therefore, data were pooled. Each data point depicted in graphs represents an individual mouse. The investigators were not blinded to allocation during experiments and outcome assessment, except when fetal thymocytes were individually analyzed by flow cytometry prior to genotyping. Significance of pairwise data was computed by unpaired two-tailed Student's t-test, with $p < 0.05$ considered statistically significance. The error bars represent standard error of the mean (SEM) values.

Mice

HEB^{fl/fl} mice have loxP sites flanking exons that encode the bHLH DNA binding and dimerization domain, which is shared by all HEB isoforms (45 [DOI](#), 69 [DOI](#)). These mice were bred to Vav-iCre transgenic mice (JAX stock #008610) (82 [DOI](#)), which deletes regions flanked by loxP sites in all hematopoietic cells (83 [DOI](#)), to generate HEB^{fl/fl};Vav-iCre (HEB cKO) mice, as previously described (8 [DOI](#), 43 [DOI](#)). All experimental mice were obtained from timed matings of HEB^{fl/fl} x HEB^{fl/fl};Vav-iCre mice, giving rise to WT and HEB cKO littermates for experimental use. Id3 deficient mice (Id3-KO) lacked Id3 in all cells due to a knock-in/knock-out allele in which the Id3 coding sequence was replaced with red fluorescent proteins (RFP) (JAX strain # 010983, B6;129S-Id3^{tm1Pzg/J}). RFP was not detectable in our analyses due to quenching during intracellular staining. Id3-KO mice were acquired on the E29/B6 background and bred onto the C57Bl/6 background for 8 generations. Id3^{+/-} mice were timed mated together to produce WT and Id3-KO littermates. Mice were bred and maintained in the Comparative Research Facility of the Sunnybrook Research Institute (Toronto, Ontario, Canada) under specific pathogen-free conditions. All animal procedures were approved by the Sunnybrook Research Institute Animal Care Committee.

Timed Matings and Embryo Harvest

Timed matings were performed by setting up mating pairs (day 0) and separating them ~16 hrs later. Embryos were harvested after 18 days (E18). Fetal thymuses were dissected, and single cell suspensions were generated by mechanical disruption and filtered through 40-micron mesh. Cells

were resuspended in 1X HBSS/BSA for sorting or flow cytometry. Embryos were processed and analyzed separately, and tail tissue was collected for genotyping of fetal mice. Genotyping was performed as previously described (45 [DOI](#)).

Flow cytometry

Antibodies were purchased from eBiosciences (San Diego, California, USA), Biolegend (San Diego, California, USA) and BD Biosciences (Mississauga, Ontario, Canada). For flow cytometry, cells were washed and incubated with Fc blocking antibody (BD Biosciences), followed by extracellular staining for surface CD4 (clone GK1.5), CD8 α (clone 53–6.7), CD3 (clone 145-2C11), TCR γ 8 (clone GL3), V γ 4 (V γ 2; clone UC3-10A6), V γ 5 (V γ 3; clone 536), V γ 1 (V γ 1.1; clone 2.11), CD27 (clone LG3-1A10), CD24 (clone M1/69), CD73 (clone TY11.8), and CD25 (clone PC615). To assess functional capacities, cells were stimulated by incubation for four h with PMA (50 ng/ml) and Ionomycin (500 ng/ml) in the presence of Brefeldin A (5mg/ml; eBioscience), washed with 1X HBSS/BSA, and incubated with Fc block before staining for surface epitopes. Cells were then fixed and permeabilized (Fix and Perm Cell Permeabilization Kit; eBioscience) and stained with antibodies against IL-17A (clone eBio17B7). For intracellular transcription factor staining, the cells were fixed, permeabilized (FoxP3 Staining Kit, eBioscience) and stained for MAF (clone sym0F1), and PLZF (clone R17-809). All flow cytometric analyses were performed using Becton-Dickenson (BD) LSRII, Fortessa, or SymphonyA5-SE cytometers. FACSDiva and FlowJo software were used for analysis. Sorting was performed on BD ARIA and BD Fusion sorters.

Cell culture

SCID.adh cells, which have been engineered to express a surface human IL-2Ra (TAC):CD3epsilon chimeric signaling molecule on the surface, were cultured as previously described (84 [DOI](#)). Cells were transduced with MIGR1 encoding GFP only, or MIGR1 encoding GFP and HEBAlt. GFP⁺ cells were sorted, expanded, and cultured overnight on plates coated with anti-TAC antibody at 5ug/mL in 500 ul of PBS, or PBS only as control. Cells were analyzed by flow cytometry for expression of CD25, and for mRNA expression of *Id3* by qRT-PCR.

RNA extraction and qRT-PCR

Total RNA was extracted from cells using TRIzol® Reagent (Invitrogen) and reverse-transcribed into complementary DNA using Superscript III (Invitrogen). Reactions for qRT-PCR were prepared using PowerUp SYBR™ Green Master Mix (ThermoFisher) or Luna® Universal qPCR Master Mix (NEB) and 0.5 μ M of primers. The qRT-PCR reaction was run and analyzed using an Applied Biosystems 7500 Fast Real-Time PCR System (ThermoFisher) and a QuantStudio™ 5 Real-Time PCR System (ThermoFisher). Values from the qRT-PCR reactions were normalized to β -actin values, and relative expression values were calculated by the delta Ct method.

Single-cell RNA sequencing (scRNA-seq) of WT and HEB cKO γ 8 T cells

E18 fetal thymuses from HEB cKO mice were dissected from embryos and individually pressed through a 40-micron mesh with a syringe plunger to create single cell suspensions. Cells were incubated with Fc block for 30 min on ice. Small aliquots from each sample were stained with CD4, CD8, and CD3 to assess genotypes, with a lack of DP indicating HEB deletion, and genotypes were verified by PCR. Five WT and five HEB cKO littermates were pooled by genotype, stained, and sorted for TCR γ 8⁺CD3⁺ cells. Samples were not hash-tagged as this technology was not available at the time of the experiments. Single cells were isolated using the 10X Chromium controller and barcoded libraries were generated using the Chromium Next GEM Single Cell 5' Kit v2 (Dual Index) (10X Genomics) at the Princess Margaret Genomics Facility (Toronto, ON, Canada). Next generation Illumina sequencing was performed to a depth of ~20,000 reads.

scRNA-seq of WT and Id3-KO DN fetal thymocytes

E18 fetal thymuses from Id3-KO mice were dissected from embryos, pressed through mesh as above, and incubated with Fc block. Embryos were genotyped by PCR, and thymocytes were pooled according to genotype (3 WT and 3 Id3-KO mice). DN cells were enriched by magnetic sorting using anti-CD4 and anti-CD8 microbeads according to manufacturer's instructions (Miltenyi Biotec). Flow-through (CD4⁺CD8⁻) cells were processed in-house using the Chromium Next GEM Single Cell 3' Kit v2 (Dual Index) (10X Genomics).

scRNA-seq data analysis of WT and HEB cKO $\gamma\delta$ T cells

FASTQ raw data files were aligned to the mm10 genome using Cell Ranger version 1.1.7 (10X Genomics) (85 [link](#)). Matrix files were analyzed using programs in R Seurat version 4.4 (46 [link](#)), as detailed in the R-Markdown files. WT and HEB cKO datasets were processed for quality control by excluding cells with more than 7% mitochondrial genes, less than 1000 unique genes, and/or less than 4000 transcripts, resulting in 1272 WT cells and 1951 HEB cKO cells for further analysis. Filtered WT and HEB cKO datasets were merged, and SCTransform was applied to the merged dataset. Cell cycle regression was performed to mitigate the influence of cell cycle heterogeneity on clustering, and cells expressing high levels of *Lyz2* were excluded to remove most myeloid cells. PCA analysis was performed (RunPCA) and used to compute a nearest neighbor graph (FindNeighbors) and identify clusters (FindClusters). UMAP plots were generated using RunUMAP and displayed using DimPlot_scCustom. FindMarkers was used to identify the top ten most differentially expressed genes between clusters which were visualized by heatmap (DoHeatmap).

Generation of gene lists and module scores

To construct an unbiased and comprehensive list of genes diagnostic for different stages and lineages of $\gamma\delta$ T cell development, we collected lists of differentially expressed genes from eight publications characterizing $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets in the fetal thymus, adult thymus, and adult peripheral tissues (13 [link](#), 21 [link](#), 47 [link](#)–51 [link](#), 86 [link](#)). Genes were filtered to remove those involved in cell cycle and metabolism, as well as NK cell receptor genes. Lists were combined, duplicates were removed, and a final list of 87 genes was obtained (Suppl. Table 1). This list was used for computation of the top ten genes per cluster that were most differentially expressed from all other clusters, visualized as a Clustered DotPlot. Comparisons with the source literature and the Immunological Genome Project (87 [link](#)) were used to categorize the clusters. $\gamma\delta$ Te1 and $\gamma\delta$ Te2 represent two types of early $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets with random assignments into “1” and “2”.

As developmental stages are continuous, not discrete, some genes were present in more than one module; however, scores were based on all genes in each module. Genes in each module are listed below.

gdTe1: *Ccr9*, *Sox13*, *Cpa3*, *Etv5*, *Sox5*, *Tox2*, *Ccr2*, *Igfbp4*, *Blk*, *Lmo4*, *Slamf1*, *Ifngr1*, *Rorc*, *Maf*, *Icos*

gdTe2: *Hivep3*, *Cd28*, *Themis*, *Slamf6*, *Sell*, *Igfbp4*, *Cd24a*, *Gzma*

gdT17p: *Blk*, *Il17re*, *Vdr*, *Il17a*, *Lmo4*, *Slamf1*, *Ifngr1*, *Rorc*, *Maf*, *Icos*

gdT17: *Il18r1*, *Il7r*, *Id2*, *Il23r*, *Il1r1*, *Cd44*

gdT1p: *Klf2*, *Nrgn*, *Cd2*, *Ms4a4b*, *Prkch*, *Nr4a1*, *Id3*

gdT1: *S1pr1*, *Eomes*, *Slamf7*, *Tyrbp*, *Ifitm1*, *Fcer1g*, *Tbx21*, *Gzmb*

abT: *Cd8a*, *Notch1*, *Cd8b1*, *Rag1*, *Rag2*, *Rmnd5a*

Module location and intensity in WT versus HEB cKO cells were visualized using split UMAPs. Comparisons of the expression of single genes between WT and HEB cKO clusters were shown using split violin plots. To compare Clusters 1 and 4, we performed FindMarkers using the Wilcox test, with a minimum of three cells per feature and three cells per group. Differentially expressed genes were displayed using an Enhanced Volcano Plot, with significance set at $\log_2$ Fold change > 0.5 and $-\log_{10}P < 10^{-26}$.

scRNA-seq data analysis of WT and Id3-KO DN thymocytes

The following analyses were conducted on the Id3-KO dataset. FASTQ raw data files were aligned to the mm39 genome using Cell Ranger. R-Seurat programs were used to filter the cells as described above in the HEB cKO dataset, resulting in 2323 WT cells and 2893 Id3-KO cells for further analysis. Datasets were merged and subjected to SCTransform as above. PCA plots were generated and used to construct UMAP plots depicting clusters in merged datasets and distribution of WT versus Id3-KO cells within each cluster by UMAP (see R-markdown file). Feature plots and violin plots were used to identify clusters with $\gamma\delta$ T cell characteristics, which were subsetted using FindClusters. ClusteredDotPlot was used to visualize the top eight most differentially expressed genes within the curated gene set described above. Split violin plots were generated to show relative expression of early and late $\gamma\delta$ T cell genes in WT versus HEB cKO cells within each cluster.

Gene ontology analysis

Genes differentially expressed between Cluster 1 and Cluster 4 with a significance of $\text{Log}_2\text{Fc} > 0.25$ and adjusted P value < 0.001 (Suppl. Table 2) were submitted to ShinyGO 8.0 (88 [link](#)) for gene ontology analysis. Pathway inclusion was set at a minimum of 5 genes with a false discovery rate (FDR) of 0.05. Genes were analyzed using the Kyoto Encyclopedia of Genes and Genomics (KEGG) pathway database (89 [link](#)) (Suppl. Table 3). Results were visualized as a bar graph showing Fold Enrichment (numbers) and $-\log_{10}(\text{FDR})$ values (colors).

Alignment of ChIP-seq data

ChIP-seq data for Rag DN3 cells bound to HEB (Rag DN3-HEB) or E2A (Rag DN3-E2A) were generated as previously described (63 [link](#)). All other files were obtained from the Cistrome database (90 [link](#)) and aligned to the mouse genome (mm38) using the Integrated Genomics Viewer (91 [link](#)). Sources were as follows: Thy anti-TCRb-Egr2, GEO accession # GSM845900 (64 [link](#)); Rag d7 aCD3-RNA pol II, GEO accession # GSM1340642 (65 [link](#)); DN3 H3K27me3, GEO accession # GSM1498423, and DN4 H3K27me3, GEO accession # GSM1498422 (92 [link](#)).

Data availability

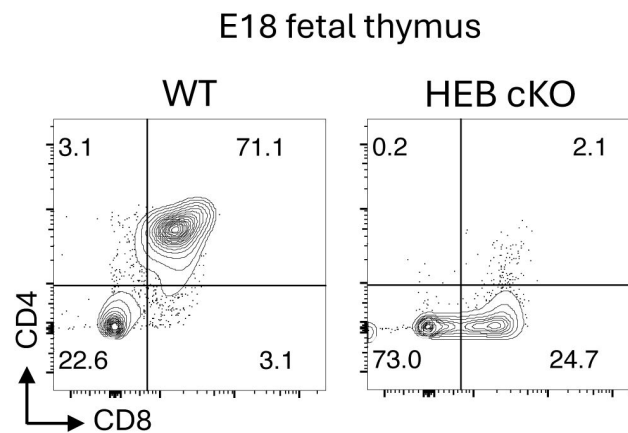
Data and materials availability. Matrix files and R-markdown code have been deposited to the Dryad repository and can be accessed at: HEB-WT scRNA-seq matrix files and R-markdown code <https://doi.org/10.5061/dryad.08kpr5cq> HEB cKO scRNA-seq matrix files <https://doi.org/10.5061/dryad.qv9s4mwqh> Id3-WT scRNA-seq matrix files and R-markdown code <https://doi.org/10.5061/dryad.j6q573nqd> Id3-KO scRNA-seq matrix files <https://doi.org/10.5061/dryad.x0k6djhvj>

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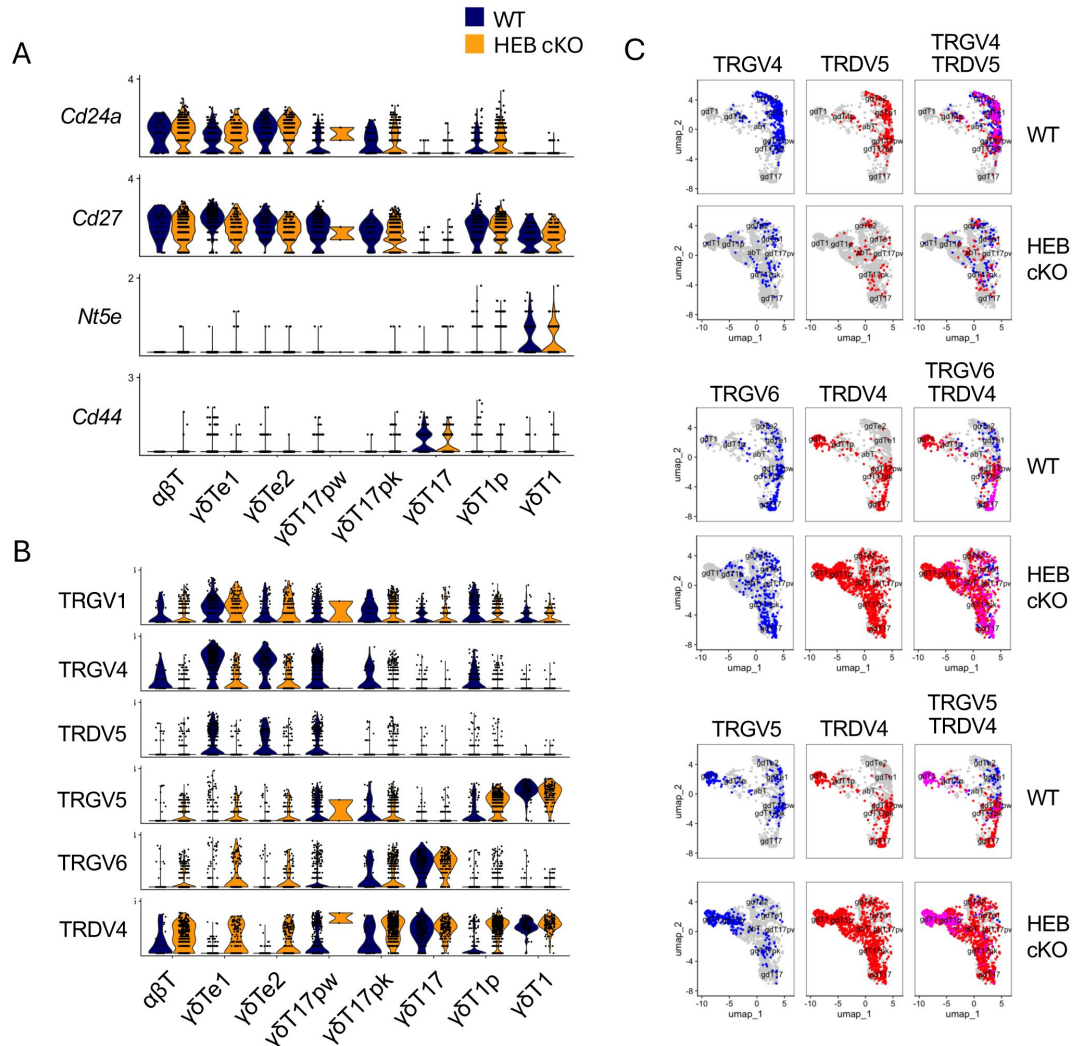
Supplementary figures



Supplementary Figure 1.

Defects in $\alpha\beta$ T cell development in E18 fetal thymus of HEB cKO mice.

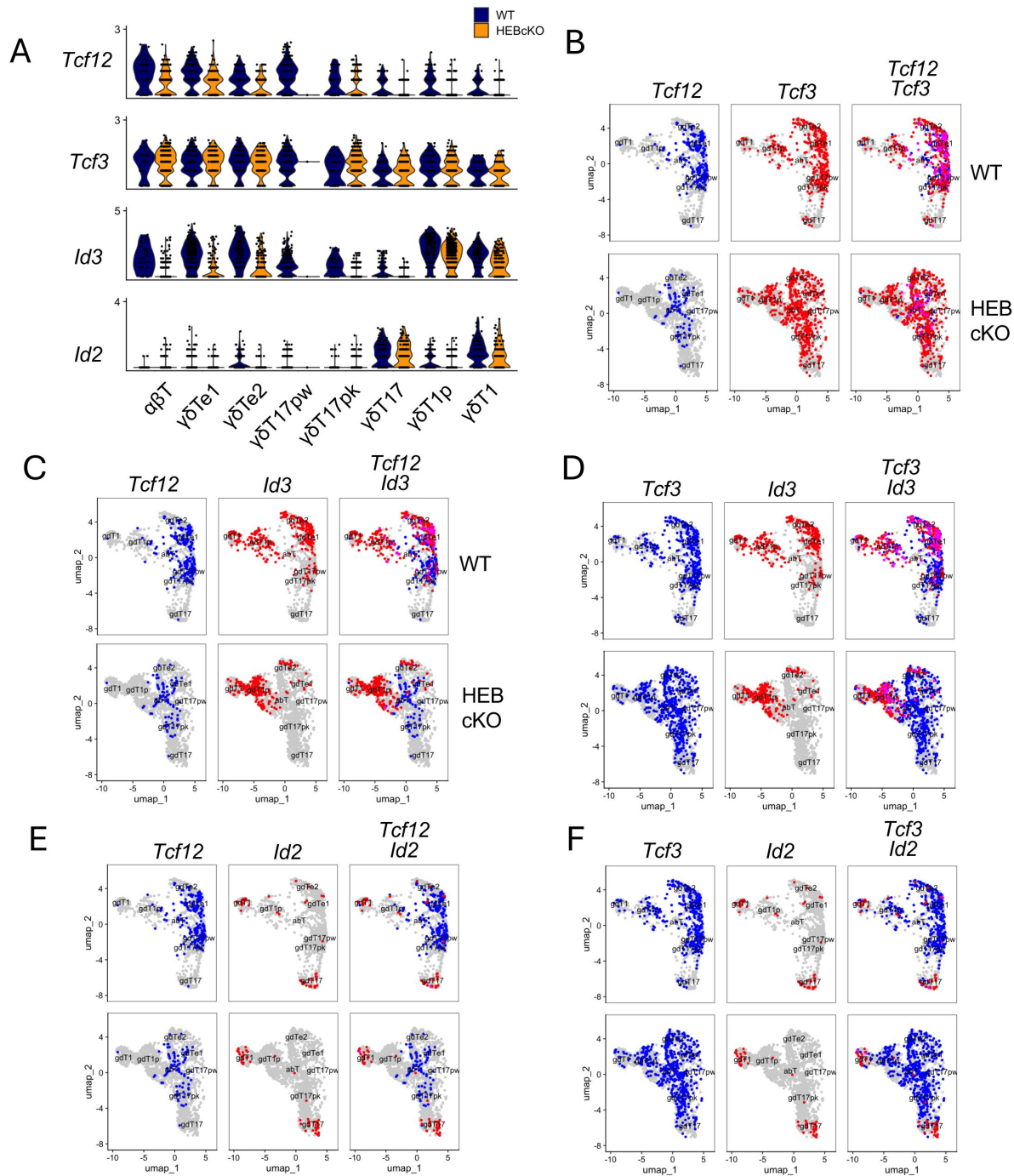
Thymocytes were dissected from E18 WT and HEB cKO littermates and subjected to flow cytometry. At E18 very few cells had become CD4 or CD8 single positives with most cells at the DP stage in WT mice. The DN to ISP and ISP to DP transitions were severely compromised in the HEB cKO fetal thymus, in agreement with the previously reports of HEB-deficient adult mice.



Supplementary Figure 2.

TRGV and TRDV expression profiling reveals depletion of TRDV4 and TRDV5 transcripts and overexpression TRDV4 in the HEB cKO fetal $\gamma\delta$ T cells.

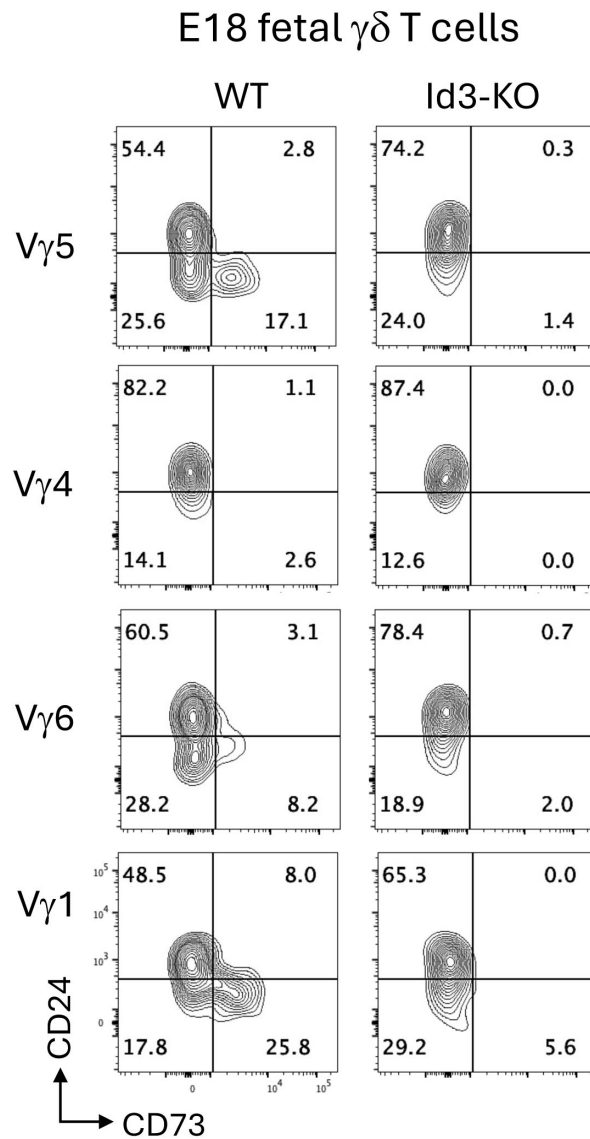
A. Violin plots of expression of canonical genes that mark $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets. **B.** Violin plots showing expression of TRGV and TRDV genes in WT versus HEB cKO by cluster. WT = blue, HEB cKO = orange. **C.** Blended split feature plots showing cells expressing TRGV chains (blue) or TRDV chains (red), and cells co-expressing TRGV and TRDV chains (pink). Co-expression in WT cells are shown on the top panel of each comparison and HEB cKO cells are shown on the bottom.



Supplementary Figure 3.

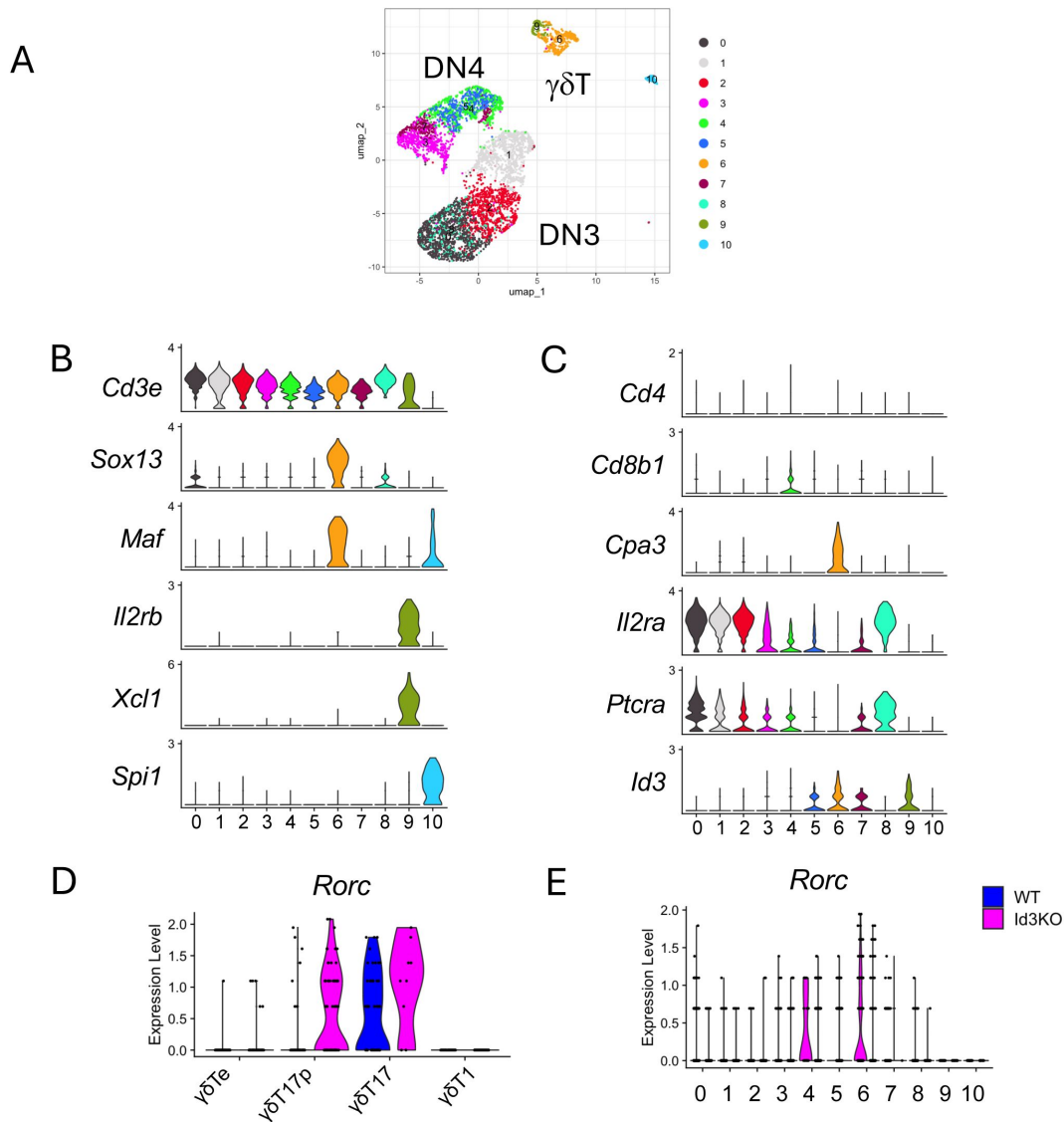
Patterns of E protein and Id protein gene expression during $\gamma\delta$ T cell development in WT and HEB cKO mice.

A. Relative expression of *Tcf12* (HEB), *Tcf3* (E2A), *Id3*, and *Id2* in WT versus HEB cKO cells by cluster. WT = blue, HEB cKO = orange. C-F. Co-expression of E protein and Id protein transcripts assessed by blended split feature plots, for (B) *Tcf12* and *Tcf3*, (C) *Tcf12* and *Id3*, (D) *Tcf3* and *Id3*, (E) *Tcf12* and *Id2*, and (F) *Tcf3* and *Id2*. Blue = E protein gene expression, red = Id gene expression, pink = co-expression.



Supplementary Figure 4.

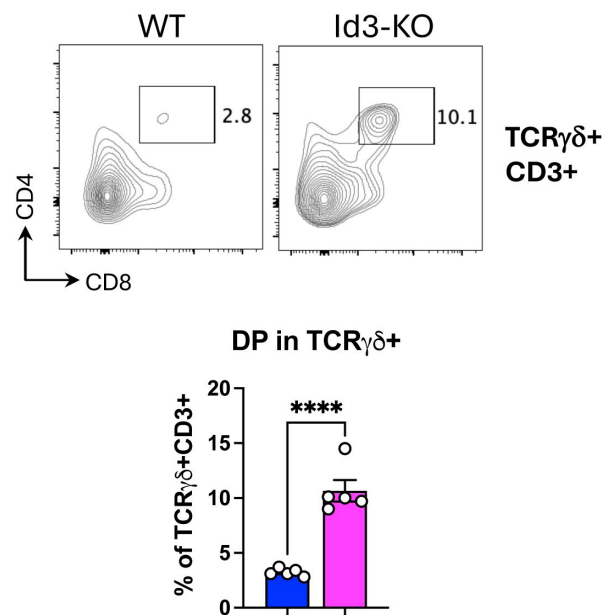
CD73 is upregulated during development of V γ 5 and V γ 1 $\gamma\delta$ T cells in WT but not Id3-KO fetal thymus.



Supplementary Figure 5.

Identification of $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets from E18 WT and Id3-KO DN cells using scRNA-seq.

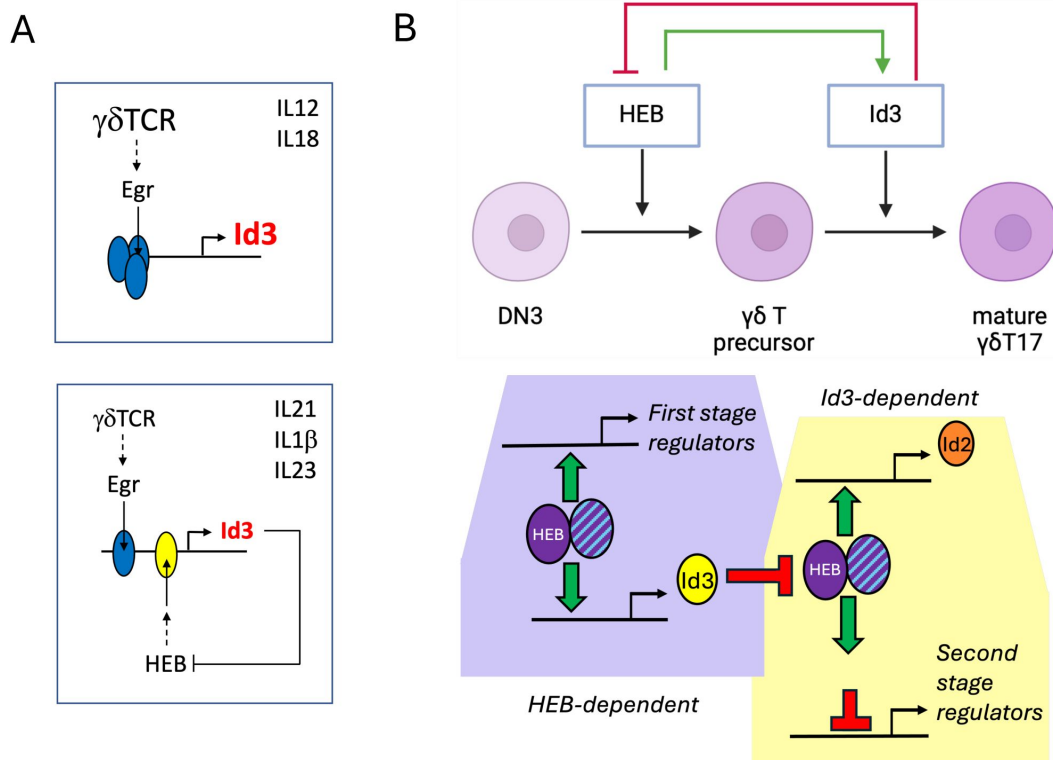
WT and Id3-KO E18 thymocytes were pooled and subjected to magnetic sorting to obtain CD4⁺CD8⁺ (DN) cells for scRNA-seq. A. UMAP of merged dataset depicting 11 clusters (0-10). B. Expression of lineage-defining genes to assign identities to clusters in merged dataset: *Cd3e* for T-lineage, *Spi1* (encodes PU.1) for myeloid lineage, *Sox13* for $\gamma\delta$ T17 lineage, *Maf* for myeloid and $\gamma\delta$ T17 lineages, and *Il2rb* and *Xcl1* for $\gamma\delta$ T1 lineage. C. Expression of genes defining DN subsets in merged datasets: *Cpa3* for DN2 and $\gamma\delta$ T cells, *Il2ra* (encodes CD25) for DN2/3 cells, *Ptcr* (encodes pre-T α) for DN3 cells, and *Id3* for $\gamma\delta$ T cells and DN4 cells. *Cd8b1* is upregulated transcriptionally before surface expression and marks $\alpha\beta$ -T lineage commitment within DN4 cells. *Cd4* was undetectable, validating our MACS enrichment strategy. D. Expression of *Rorc* in WT versus Id3-KO cells in $\gamma\delta$ T cell subsets. E. *Rorc* expression in all WT and Id3-KO clusters.



Supplementary Figure 6.

$\gamma\delta$ TCR $^+$ cells from E18 Id3-KO mice include a population of CD4 $^+$ CD8 $^+$ cells, indicating diversion to the $\alpha\beta$ -T lineage program.

E18 fetal thymocytes were subjected to flow cytometry. Cells were gated on the TCR $\gamma\delta^+$ CD3 $^+$ population and analyzed for expression of CD4 and CD8 which was quantified in a bar graph depicting the percentage of CD4 $^+$ CD8 $^+$ (DP) cells within the $\gamma\delta$ TCR $^+$ population.



Supplementary Figure 7.

Model for HEB and Id3 requirements in the development and maturation of $\gamma\delta$ T17 cells.

A. Strong $\gamma\delta$ TCR signaling induces high levels of Egr2, which are sufficient to drive Id3 upregulation without HEB, whereas HEB is also required under lower $\gamma\delta$ TCR signaling conditions. Distinct cytokine signals also participate in Id3 modulation and $\gamma\delta$ T cell lineage choice. **B.** $\gamma\delta$ T17 development occurs in two stages, the first of which is HEB-dependent, and the second of which is Id3-dependent. HEB induces Id3 during the first stage, which acts in a negative feedback loop to inhibit HEB activity during the second stage. The absence of Id3 allows higher E protein activity, which inhibits second stage regulators but also results in Id2 upregulation, providing partial compensation for the loss of Id3.

Additional information

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Author contributions

J.S.S. and M.K.A. conceptualized the study. E.S.R., M.S.G. and C.J.G. developed high parameter flow cytometry panels. J.S.S., E.S.R., and J.D.R. collected the flow cytometry data, and J.S.S. sorted cells for the scRNA-seq experiments. M.K.A. analyzed the scRNA-seq data, assisted by H.W. and V.R., and generated the figures. V.R. and H.W. performed the *Id3* scRNA-seq experiment. J.D.R. and J.J.L. performed the cell culture experiments. Funding was acquired by M.K.A., J.C.Z.P., D.L.W. and C.M. M.K.A., J.C.Z.P., D.L.W. and C.M. interpreted the data and formed the model. M.K.A. wrote the first draft of the manuscript, and all authors contributed to the final manuscript.

Definitions of Acronyms and Abbreviations

- TCR: T cell receptor
- Id: Inhibitor of DNA binding
- HEB: HeLa binding box transcription factor
- IL: interleukin
- E: embryonic day
- V: variable region
- Egr: early growth response
- DP: CD4⁺CD8⁺ double positive thymocytes
- DN: CD4⁺CD8⁻ double negative thymocytes
- UMAP: uniform manifold approximation and projection for dimensional reduction
- PCA: principal component analysis
- sc: single cell
- IFN: interferon

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Additional files

Supplementary Table 1 [↗](#)

Supplementary Table 2 [↗](#)

Supplementary Table 3 [↗](#)

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Reviewer #1 (Public review):

The authors use Flow cytometry and scRNA seq to identify and characterize the defect in gdT17 cell development from HEB f/f, Vav-icre (HEB cKO), and Id3 germline-deficient mice. HEB cKO mice showed defects in the gdT17 program at an early stage, and failed to properly

upregulate expression of Id3 along with other genes downstream of TCR signaling. Id3KO mice showed a later defect in maturation. The results together indicate HEB and Id3 act sequentially during gdT17 development. The authors further showed that HEB and TCR signaling synergize to upregulate Id3 expression in the Scid-adh DN3-like T cell line. Analysis of previously published ChIP-seq data revealed binding of HEB (and Egr2) at overlapping regulatory regions near Id3 in DN3 cells.

The study provides insight into mechanisms by which HEB and Id3 act to mediate gdT17 specification and maturation. The work is well performed and clearly presented. We only have minor comments.

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Reviewer #2 (Public review):

Summary:

The manuscript by Selvaratnam et al. defines how the transcription factor HEB integrates with TCR signaling to regulate Id3 expression in the context of gdT17 maturation in the fetal thymus. Using conditional HEB ablation driven by Vav Cre, flow cytometry, scRNA-seq, and reanalysis of ChIP-seq data the authors, provide evidence for a sequential model in which HEB and TCR-induced Egr2 cooperatively upregulate Id3, enabling gdT17 maturation and limiting diversion to the ab lineages. The work provides an important mechanistic insight into how the E/ID-protein axis coordinates gd T cell specification and effector maturation.

Strengths include:

- (1) The proposed model that HEB primes, TCR induces, and Id3 stabilizes gdT17 cells in embryonal development is elegant and consistent with the findings.
- (2) The choice of animal models and the study of a precise developmental window.
- (3) The cross-validation of flow, scRNA-seq, and ChIP-seq reanalyses strengthens the conclusions.
- (4) The study clarifies the dual role of Id3, first as an HEB-dependent maturation factor for gdT17 cells, and as a suppressor of diversion to the ab lineages.

Weaknesses:

- (1) The ChIP-seq reanalysis indicates overlapping HEB, E2A, and Egr2 peaks ~60 kb upstream of Id3. Given that the Egr2 data are not generated using the same thymocyte subsets, some form of validation should be considered for the co-binding of HEB and Egr2, potentially ChIP-qPCR in sorted gdT17 progenitors.
- (2) E2A expression is not affected in HEB-deficient cells, raising the question of partial compensation, a point that should be specifically discussed.
- (3) All experiments are done at E18, when fetal gdT17 development predominates. The discussion could address whether these mechanisms extend to neonatal or adult gdT17 subsets.

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Reviewer #3 (Public review):**Summary:**

The authors of this manuscript have addressed a key concept in T cell development: how early thymus gd T cell subsets are specified and the elements that govern gd T17 versus other gd T cell subsets or ab T cell subsets are specified. They show that the transcriptional regulator HEB/Tcf12 plays a critical role in specifying the gd T17 lineage and, intriguingly, that it upregulates the inhibitor Id3, which is later required for further gd T17 maturation.

Strengths:

The conclusions drawn by the authors are amply supported by a detailed analysis of various stages of T cell maturation in WT and KO mouse strains at the single cell level, both phenotypically, by flow cytometry for various diagnostic surface markers, and transcriptionally, by single cell sequencing. Their conclusions are balanced and well supported by the data and citations of previous literature.

Weaknesses:

I actually found this work to be quite comprehensive. I have a few suggestions for additional analyses the authors could explore that are unrelated to the predominant conclusions of the manuscript, but I failed to find major flaws in the current work.

I note that HEB is expressed in many hematopoietic lineages from the earliest progenitors and throughout T cell development. It is also noteworthy that abortive gamma and delta TCR rearrangements have been observed in early NK cells and ILCs, suggesting that, particularly in early thymic development, specification of these lineages may have lower fidelity. It might prove interesting to see whether their single-cell sequencing or flow data reveal changes in the frequency of these other T-cell-related lineages. Is it possible that HEB is playing a role not only in the fidelity of gdT17 cell specification, but also perhaps in the separation of T cells from NK cells and ILCs or the frequency of DN1, DN2, and DN3 cells? Perhaps their single-cell sequencing data or flow analyses could examine the frequency of these cells? That minor caveat aside, I find this to be an extremely exciting body of work.

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